is Penelope coping—what does it mean to wait or not to wait? How is Telemachus taking it—is growing up all about being "his father's son"? Held up for a decade by hostile gods and amorous goddesses, what choices are left for Odysseus? Above all, how may he be father, husband, and king again?

The *Odyssey* has lived in the Western imagination as a story of monsters, shipwrecks, and adventures that take readers to strange lands, including the Underworld. But the epic is also a story about self-understanding, or transformation, gained through a physical or psychological journey of twenty years—of "godlike Odysseus," of "wise" Penelope, and of "clear-headed" Telemachus. Reading the epic in our times, how do we see the heroes' choices? What do we make of the Greek ideas of hospitality, immortality, and time as moving in a cycle?

The epic opens in the last month of Odysseus's homecoming and flashes back to scenes in Troy and subsequent encounters before the journey's end. It comprises twenty-four books, which can be divided into the journey of Telemachus (Books 1–4); the wanderings and homecoming of Odysseus (Books 5–12); and the ultimate reunion and revenge (Books 13–24). This selection contains excerpts from seven books (1, 2, 5, 16, 19, 21, 23) where Telemachus, Odysseus and Penelope take centre stage.

The *Odyssey* was written in pre-classical Homeric Greek. We read it in an English translation by Stanley Lombardo who, publishing the work in 2000, tries to capture the oral flavour of Homer by finding a balance between poetic composition and oral performance. His short verse lines impress a critic as "fresh, quick, and verbally engaging to the modern ear."[1]

Julie Chiu

[1] A remark of Joseph Russo, quoted on the back cover of *The Odyssey*, tr. Stanley Lombardo (Indianapolis/Cambridge: Hackett, 2007).

from

Odyssey

by Homer

ODYSSEY 1

SPEAK, MEMORY—
Of the cunning hero,
The wanderer, blown off course time and again
After he plundered Troy's sacred heights.
Speak
Of all the cities he saw, the minds he grasped,
The suffering deep in his heart at sea
As he struggled to survive and bring his men home
But could not save them, hard as he tried—
The fools—destroyed by their own recklessness
When they ate the oxen of Hyperion the Sun,
And that god snuffed out their day of return.

Of these things,
Speak, Immortal One,
And tell the tale once more in our time.

From Homer, *Odyssey*, translated by Stanley Lombardo. Copyright © 2000 Hackett Publishing Company, Inc. Reprinted by permission of Hackett Publishing Company, Inc. All rights reserved.

By now, all the others who had fought at Troy—
At least those who had survived the war and the sea—
Were safely back home. Only Odysseus
Still longed to return to his home and his wife.
The nymph Calypso, a powerful goddess—
And beautiful—was clinging to him
In her caverns and yearned to possess him.
The seasons rolled by, and the year came
In which the gods spun the thread
For Odysseus to return home to Ithaca,
Though not even there did his troubles end,
Even with his dear ones around him.
All the gods pitied him, except Poseidon,
Who stormed against the godlike hero
Until he finally reached his own native land.

But Poseidon was away now, among the Ethiopians,
Those burnished people at the ends of the earth—
Some near the sunset, some near the sunrise—
To receive a grand sacrifice of rams and bulls.
There he sat, enjoying the feast.
The other gods
Were assembled in the halls of Olympian Zeus,
And the Father of Gods and Men was speaking.
He couldn't stop thinking about Aegisthus,
Whom Agamemnon's son, Orestes, had killed:

"Mortals! They are always blaming the gods
For their troubles, when their own witlessness
Causes them more than they were destined for!
Take Aegisthus now. He marries Agamemnon's
Lawful wife and murders the man on his return
Knowing it meant disaster—because we did warn him,
Sent our messenger, quicksilver Hermes,
To tell him not to kill the man and marry his wife,
Or Agamemnon's son, Orestes, would pay him back
When he came of age and wanted his inheritance.
Hermes told him all that, but his good advice
Meant nothing to Aegisthus. Now he's paid in full."

Athena glared at him with her owl-grey eyes:

"Yes, O our Father who art most high—
That man got the death he richly deserved,
And so perish all who would do the same.
But it's Odysseus I'm worried about,
That discerning, ill-fated man. He's suffered
So long, separated from his dear ones,
On an island that lies in the center of the sea,
A wooded isle that is home to a goddess,
The daughter of Atlas, whose dread mind knows
All the depths of the sea and who supports
The tall pillars that keep earth and heaven apart.
His daughter detains the poor man in his grief,
Sweet-talking him constantly, trying to charm him
Into forgetting Ithaca. But Odysseus,
Longing to see even the smoke curling up
From his land, simply wants to die. And yet you
Never think of him, Olympian. Didn't Odysseus
Please you with sacrifices beside the Greek ships
At Troy? Why is Odysseus so odious, Zeus?"

Zeus in his thunderhead had an answer for her:

"Quite a little speech you've let slip through your teeth,
Daughter. How could I forget godlike Odysseus?
No other mortal has a mind like his, or offers
Sacrifice like him to the deathless gods in heaven.
But Poseidon is stiff and cold with anger
Because Odysseus blinded his son, the Cyclops
Polyphemus, the strongest of all the Cyclopes,
Nearly a god. The nymph Thoösa bore him,
Daughter of Phorcys, lord of the barren brine,
After mating with Poseidon in a scalloped sea-cave.
The Earthshaker has been after Odysseus
Ever since, not killing him, but keeping him away
From his native land. But come now,
Let's all put our heads together and find a way
To bring Odysseus home. Poseidon will have to

Put aside his anger. He can't hold out alone
Against the will of all the immortals."

And Athena, the owl-eyed goddess, replied:

"Father Zeus, whose power is supreme,
If the blessed gods really do want
Odysseus to return to his home,
We should send Hermes, our quicksilver herald,
To the island of Ogygia without delay
To tell that nymph of our firm resolve
That long-suffering Odysseus gets to go home.
I myself will go to Ithaca
To put some spirit into his son—
Have him call an assembly of the long-haired Greeks
And rebuke the whole lot of his mother's suitors.
They have been butchering his flocks and herds.
I'll escort him to Sparta and the sands of Pylos
So he can make inquiries about his father's return
And win for himself a name among men."

Athena spoke, and she bound on her feet
The beautiful sandals, golden, immortal,
That carry her over landscape and seascape
On a puff of wind. And she took the spear,
Bronze-tipped and massive, that the Daughter uses
To level battalions of heroes in her wrath.
She shot down from the peaks of Olympus
To Ithaca, where she stood on the threshold
Of Odysseus' outer porch. Holding her spear,
She looked like Mentes, the Taphian captain,
And her eyes rested on the arrogant suitors.

They were playing dice in the courtyard,
Enjoying themselves, seated on the hides of oxen
They themselves had slaughtered. They were attended
By heralds and servants, some of whom were busy

Blending water and wine in large mixing bowls,
Others wiping down the tables with sponges
And dishing out enormous servings of meat.

Telemachus spotted her first.
He was sitting with the suitors, nursing
His heart's sorrow, picturing in his mind
His noble father, imagining he had returned
And scattered the suitors, and that he himself,
Telemachus, was respected at last.
Such were his reveries as he sat with the suitors.
And then he saw Athena.
He went straight to the porch,
Indignant that a guest had been made to wait so long.
Going up to her he grasped her right hand in his
And took her spear, and his words had wings:

"Greetings, stranger. You are welcome here.
After you've had dinner, you can tell us what you need."

Telemachus spoke, and Pallas Athena
Followed him into the high-roofed hall.
When they were inside he placed her spear
In a polished rack beside a great column
Where the spears of Odysseus stood in a row.
Then he covered a beautifully wrought chair
With a linen cloth and had her sit on it
With a stool under her feet. He drew up
An intricately painted bench for himself
And arranged their seats apart from the suitors
So that his guest would not lose his appetite
In their noisy and uncouth company—
And so he could inquire about his absent father.
A maid poured water from a silver pitcher
Into a golden basin for them to wash their hands
And then set up a polished table nearby.
Another serving woman, grave and dignified,

Set out bread and generous helpings
From the other dishes she had. A carver set down
Cuts of meat by the platter and golden cups.
Then a herald came by and poured them wine.

Now the suitors swaggered in. They sat down
In rows on benches and chairs. Heralds
Poured water over their hands, maidservants
Brought around bread in baskets, and young men
Filled mixing bowls to the brim with wine.
The suitors helped themselves to all this plenty,
And when they had their fill of food and drink,
They turned their attention to the other delights,
Dancing and song, that round out a feast.
A herald handed a beautiful zither
To Phemius, who sang for the suitors,
Though against his will. Sweeping the strings
He struck up a song. And Telemachus,
Putting his head close to Pallas Athena's
So the others wouldn't hear, said this to her:

"Please don't take offense if I speak my mind.
It's easy for them to enjoy the harper's song,
Since they are eating another man's stores
Without paying anything—the stores of a man
Whose white bones lie rotting in the rain
On some distant shore, or still churn in the waves.
If they ever saw him make landing on Ithaca
They would pray for more foot speed
Instead of more gold or fancy clothes.
But he's met a bad end, and it's no comfort to us
When some traveler tells us he's on his way home.
The day has long passed when he's coming home.
But tell me this, and tell me the truth:
Who are you, and where do you come from?
Who are your parents? What kind of ship
Brought you here? How did your sailors
Guide you to Ithaca, and how large is your crew?
I don't imagine you came here on foot.

And tell me this, too. I'd like to know,
Is this your first visit here, or are you
An old friend of my father's, one of the many
Who have come to our house over the years?"

Athena's seagrey eyes glinted as she said:

"I'll tell you nothing but the unvarnished truth.
I am Mentes, son of Anchialus, and proud of it.
I am also captain of the seafaring Taphians.
I just pulled in with my ship and my crew,
Sailing the deep purple to foreign ports.
We're on our way to Cyprus with a cargo of iron
To trade for copper. My ship is standing
Offshore of wild country away from the city,
In Rheithron harbor under Neion's woods.
You and I have ties of hospitality,
Just as our fathers did, from a long way back.
Go and ask old Laertes. They say he never
Comes to town any more, lives out in the country,
A hard life with just an old woman to help him.
She gets him his food and drink when he comes in
From the fields, all worn out from trudging across
The ridge of his vineyard plot.
I have come
Because they say your father has returned,
But now I see the gods have knocked him off course.
He's not dead, though, not godlike Odysseus,
No way in the world. No, he's alive all right.
It's the sea keeps him back, detained on some island
In the middle of the sea, held captive by savages.
And now I will prophesy for you, as the gods
Put it in my heart and as I think it will be,
Though I am no soothsayer or reader of birds.
Odysseus will not be gone much longer
From his native land, not even if iron chains
Hold him. He knows every trick there is
And will think of some way to come home.
But now tell me this, and I want the truth:

Tall as you are, are you Odysseus' son?
You bear a striking resemblance to him,
Especially in the head and those beautiful eyes.
We used to spend quite a bit of time together
Before he sailed for Troy with the Argive fleet.
Since then, we haven't seen each other at all."

Telemachus took a deep breath and said:

"You want the truth, and I will give it to you.
My mother says that Odysseus is my father.
I don't know this myself. No one witnesses
His own begetting. If I had my way, I'd be the son
Of a man fortunate enough to grow old at home.
But it's the man with the most dismal fate of all
They say I was born from—since you want to know."

Athena's seagrey eyes glinted as she said:

"Well, the gods have made sure your family name
Will go on; since Penelope has borne a son like you.
But there is one other thing I want you to tell me.
What kind of a party is this? What's the occasion?
Some kind of banquet? A wedding feast?
It's no neighborly potluck, that's for sure,
The way this rowdy crowd is carrying on
All through the house. Any decent man
Would be outraged if he saw this behavior."

Telemachus breathed in the salt air and said:

"Since you ask me these questions as my guest—
This, no doubt, was once a perfect house,
Wealthy and fine, when its master was still home.
But the gods frowned and changed all that
When they whisked him off the face of the earth.
I wouldn't grieve for him so much if he were dead,
Gone down with his comrades in the town of Troy,
Or died in his friends' arms after winding up the war.

The entire Greek army would have buried him then,
And great honor would have passed on to his son.
But now the whirlwinds have snatched him away
Without a trace. He's vanished, gone, and left me
Pain and sorrow. And he's not the only cause
I have to grieve. The gods have given me other trials.
All of the nobles who rule the islands—
Doulichium, Samê, wooded Zacynthus—
And all those with power on rocky Ithaca
Are courting my mother and ruining our house.
She refuses to make a marriage she hates
But can't stop it either. They are eating us
Out of house and home, and will kill me someday."

And Pallas Athena, with a flash of anger:

"Damn them! You really do need Odysseus back.
Just let him lay his hands on these mangy dogs!
If only he would come through that door now
With a helmet and shield and a pair of spears,
Just as he was when I saw him first,
Drinking and enjoying himself in our house
On his way back from Ephyre. Odysseus
Had sailed there to ask Mermerus' son, Ilus,
For some deadly poison for his arrowheads.
Ilus, out of fear of the gods' anger,
Would not give him any, but my father
Gave him some, because he loved him dearly.
That's the Odysseus I want the suitors to meet.
They wouldn't live long enough to get married!
But it's on the knees of the gods now
Whether he comes home and pays them back
Right here in his halls, or doesn't.
So it's up to you
To find a way to drive them out of your house.
Now pay attention and listen to what I'm saying.
Tomorrow you call an assembly and make a speech
To these heroes, with the gods as witnesses.
The suitors you order to scatter, each to his own.

Your mother—if in her heart she wants to marry—
Goes back to her powerful father's house.
Her kinfolk and he can arrange the marriage,
And the large dowry that should go with his daughter.
And my advice for you, if you will take it,
Is to launch your best ship, with twenty oarsmen,
And go make inquiries about your long-absent father.
Someone may tell you something, or you may hear
A rumor from Zeus, which is how news travels best.
Sail to Pylos first and ask godly Nestor,
Then go over to Sparta and red-haired Menelaus.
He was the last home of all the bronzeclad Greeks.
If you hear your father's alive and on his way home,
You can grit your teeth and hold out one more year.
If you hear he's dead, among the living no more,
Then come home yourself to your ancestral land,
Build him a barrow and celebrate the funeral
Your father deserves. Then marry off your mother.
After you've done all that, think up some way
To kill the suitors in your house either openly
Or by setting a trap. You've got to stop
Acting like a child. You've outgrown that now.
Haven't you heard how Orestes won glory
Throughout the world when he killed Aegisthus,
The shrewd traitor who murdered his father?
You have to be aggressive, strong—look at how big
And well-built you are—so you will leave a good name.
Well, I'm off to my ship and my men,
Who are no doubt wondering what's taking me so long.
You've got a job to do. Remember what I said."

And Telemachus, in his clear-headed way:

"My dear guest, you speak to me as kindly
As a father to his son. I will not forget your words.
I know you're anxious to leave, but please stay
So you can bathe and relax before returning
To your ship, taking with you a costly gift,
Something quite fine, a keepsake from me,

The sort of thing a host gives to his guest."

And Athena, her eyes grey as saltwater:

"No, I really do want to get on with my journey.
Whatever gift you feel moved to make,
Give it to me on my way back home,
Yes, something quite fine. It will get you as good."

With these words the Grey-eyed One was gone,
Flown up and away like a seabird. And as she went
She put courage in Telemachus' heart
And made him think of his father even more than before.
Telemachus' mind soared. He knew it had been a god,
And like a god himself he rejoined the suitors.

They were sitting hushed in silence, listening
To the great harper as he sang the tale
Of the hard journeys home that Pallas Athena
Ordained for the Greeks on their way back from Troy.

His song drifted upstairs, and Penelope,
Wise daughter of Icarius, took it all in.
She came down the steep stairs of her house—
Not alone, two maids trailed behind—
And when she had come among the suitors
She stood shawled in light by a column
That supported the roof of the great house,
Hiding her cheeks behind her silky veils,
Grave handmaidens standing on either side.
And she wept as she addressed the brilliant harper:

"Phemius, you know many other songs
To soothe human sorrows, songs of the exploits
Of gods and men. Sing one of those
To your enraptured audience as they sit
Sipping their wine. But stop singing this one,
This painful song that always tears at my heart.
I am already sorrowful, constantly grieving

For my husband, remembering him, a man
Renowned in Argos and throughout all Hellas."

And Telemachus said to her coolly:

"Mother, why begrudge our singer
Entertaining us as he thinks best?
Singers are not responsible; Zeus is,
Who gives what he wants to every man on earth.
No one can blame Phemius for singing the doom
Of the Danaans: it's always the newest song
An audience praises most. For yourself,
You'll just have to endure it and listen.
Odysseus was not the only man at Troy
Who didn't come home. Many others perished.
You should go back upstairs and take care of your work,
Spinning and weaving, and have the maids do theirs.
Speaking is for men, for all men, but for me
Especially, since I am the master of this house."

Penelope was stunned and turned to go,
Her son's masterful words pressed to her heart.
She went up the stairs to her room with her women
And wept for Odysseus, her beloved husband,
Until grey-eyed Athena cast sleep on her eyelids.

All through the shadowy halls the suitors
Broke into an uproar, each of them praying
To lie in bed with her. Telemachus cut them short:

"Suitors of my mother—you arrogant pigs—
For now, we're at a feast. No shouting, please!
There's nothing finer than hearing
A singer like this, with a voice like a god's.
But in the morning we will sit in the meeting ground,
So that I can tell all of you in broad daylight
To get out of my house. Fix yourselves feasts
In each others' houses, use up your own stockpiles.
But if it seems better and more profitable

For one man to be eaten out of house and home
Without compensation—then eat away!
For my part, I will pray to the gods eternal
That Zeus grant me requital: Death for you
Here in my house. With no compensation."

Thus Telemachus. And they all bit their lips
And marveled at how boldly he had spoken to them.
Then Antinous, son of Eupeithes, replied:

"Well, Telemachus, it seems the gods, no less,
Are teaching you how to be a bold public speaker.
May the son of Cronus never make you king
Here on Ithaca, even if it is your birthright."

And Telemachus, taking in a breath:

"It may make you angry, Antinous,
But I'll tell you something. I wouldn't mind a bit
If Zeus granted me this—if he made me king.
You think this is the worst fate a man can have?
It's not so bad to be king. Your house grows rich,
And you're held in great honor yourself. But,
There are many other lords on seawashed Ithaca,
Young and old, and any one of them
Could get to be king, now that Odysseus is dead.
But I will be master of my own house
And of the servants that Odysseus left me."

Then Eurymachus, Polybus' son, responded:

"It's on the knees of the gods, Telemachus,
Which man of Greece will rule this island.
But you keep your property and rule your house,
And may no man ever come to wrest them away
From you by force, not while men live in Ithaca.
But I want to ask you, sir, about your visitor.
Where did he come from, what port
Does he call home, where are his ancestral fields?

Did he bring news of your father's coming
Or was he here on business of his own?
He sure up and left in a hurry, wouldn't stay
To be known. Yet by his looks he was no tramp."

And Telemachus, with a sharp response:

"Eurymachus, my father is not coming home.
I no longer trust any news that may come,
Or any prophecy my mother may have gotten
From a seer she has summoned up to the house.
My guest was a friend of my father's from Taphos.
He says he is Mentes, son of Anchialus
And captain of the seafaring Taphians."

Thus Telemachus. But in his heart he knew
It was an immortal goddess.

And now
The young men plunged into their entertainment,
Singing and dancing until the twilight hour.
They were still at it when the evening grew dark,
Then one by one went to their own houses to rest.

Telemachus' room was off the beautiful courtyard,
Built high and with a surrounding view.
There he went to his bed, his mind teeming,
And with him, bearing blazing torches,
Went true-hearted Eurycleia, daughter of Ops
And Peisenor's grandaughter. Long ago,
Laertes had bought her for a small fortune
When she was still a girl. He paid twenty oxen
And honored her in his house as he honored
His wedded wife, but he never slept with her
Because he would rather avoid his wife's wrath.
Of all the women, she loved Telemachus the most
And had nursed him as a baby. Now she bore
The blazing torches as Telemachus opened
The doors to his room and sat on his bed.

He pulled off his soft tunic and laid it
In the hands of the wise old woman, and she
Folded it and smoothed it and hung it on a peg
Beside the corded bed. Then she left the room,
Pulled the door shut by its silver handle,
And drew the bolt home with the strap.

There Telemachus
Lay wrapped in a fleece all the night through,
Pondering the journey Athena had shown him.

ODYSSEY 2

Dawn's pale rose fingers brushed across the sky,
And Odysseus' son got out of bed and dressed.
He slung his sharp sword around his shoulder,
Then tied oiled leather sandals onto his feet,
And walked out of the bedroom like a god.
Wasting no time, he ordered the heralds
To call an assembly. The heralds' cries
Rang out through the town, and the men
Gathered quickly, their long hair streaming.
Telemachus strode along carrying a spear
And accompanied by two lean hounds.
Athena shed a silver grace upon him,
And everyone marveled at him as he entered.
The elders made way as he took his father's seat.

First to speak was the hero Aegyptius,
A man bowed with age and wise beyond telling.
His son, Antiphus, had gone off to Troy
In the ships with Odysseus (and was killed
In the cave of the Cyclops, who made of him

His last savage meal). Of three remaining sons,
One, Eurynomus, ran with the suitors,
And the other two kept their father's farm.
But Aegyptius couldn't stop mourning the one that was lost
And was weeping for him as he spoke out now:

"Hear me now, men of Ithaca.
We have never once held assembly or sat
In council since Odysseus left.
Who has called us together today?
Which of the young men, or of the elders,
Has such urgent business as this?
Has he had news of the army's return,
Some early report he wants to tell us about?
Or is there some other public matter
He wants to address? He's a fine man
In my eyes; and may Zeus bless him."

Telemachus was glad to hear these words,
And he rose from his seat, eager to speak.
There he stood, in the midst of the assembly,
And the herald Peisenor, a wise counselor,
Placed the staff in the hands of Odysseus' son.
In his speech he addressed old Aegyptius first:

"You won't have to look very far to find out
Who called this assembly. I called it myself.
No, I have not had news of the army's return,
Any early report I could tell you about.
Nor is there any other public matter
I want to address. It's a private matter,
My own need. Trouble has come to my house
In two forms. First, I have lost my noble father.
He was your king once, and like a father
To all of you, gentle and kind. And now,
There is even greater trouble, far greater,
Which will destroy my house and home.
Suitors have latched on to my mother,
Against her will, and they are the sons

Of the noblest men here. They shrink
From going to her father Icarius' house
So that he could arrange his daughter's dowry
And give her away to the man he likes best.
Instead, they gather at our house day after day,
Slaughtering our oxen and sheep and fat goats,
Living high and drinking wine recklessly.
We've lost almost everything, because
We don't have Odysseus to protect our house.
We can't defend ourselves. If it came to a fight
We would only show how pathetic we are.
Not that I wouldn't defend myself
If I had the power. Things have gone too far.
The ruin of my house has become a public disgrace.
You should all be indignant, and feel shame
Before your neighbors, and fear the wrath
Of the gods, who may yet turn against you.
I beg you by Olympian Zeus and by Themis,
Who calls and dismisses assemblies of men,
Stop this, my friends, and let me be alone
In my grief—unless my father, Odysseus,
Was your enemy and did you some harm
And now you are paying me back in malice
By urging these suitors on. Better for me
If you yourselves, Ithacans all,
Were to eat up my treasures and flocks.
Then I might get restitution someday.
I'd go through the town and bend people's ears
And ask for our goods until they were all given back.
But there is nothing I can do now. There's no cure
For what you are making me suffer now."

He spoke in anger, bursting into tears
As he threw the scepter onto the ground.
The crowd was motionless with pity. No one
Had the heart to respond to him harshly,
Except Antinous, who now said:

"Well, the big speaker, the mighty orator.

You've got some nerve, Telemachus,
Laying the blame on us. It's not the suitors
Who are at fault, but your own mother,
Who knows more tricks than any woman alive.
It's been three years now, almost four,
Since she's been toying with our affections.
She encourages each man, leading us on,
Sending messages. But her mind is set elsewhere.
Here's just one of the tricks she devised:
She set up a great loom in the main hall
And started weaving a sizeable fabric
With a very fine thread, and she said to us:

'Young men—my suitors, since Odysseus is dead—
Eager as you are to marry me, you must wait
Until I finish this robe—it would be a shame
To waste my spinning—a shroud for the hero
Laertes, when death's doom lays him low.
I fear the Achaean women would reproach me
If he should lie in death shroudless for all his wealth.'

"We were persuaded by this appeal to our honor.
Every day she would weave at the great loom,
And every night she would unweave by torchlight.
She fooled us for three years with her craft.
But in the fourth year, as the seasons rolled by,
And the moons waned, and the days dragged on,
One of her women who knew all about it
Told us, and we caught her unweaving
The gloried shroud. Then we forced her to finish it.
Now here is the suitors' answer to you,
And let every Achaean hear it as well:
Send your mother away with orders to marry
Whichever man her father likes best.
But if she goes on like this much longer,
Torturing us with all she knows and has,
All the gifts Athena has given her,
Her talent for handiwork, her good sense,
Her cleverness—all of which go far beyond

That of any of the heroines of old,
Tyro or Alcmene or garlanded Mycene,
Not one of whom had a mind like Penelope's,
Even though now she is not thinking straight—
We will continue to eat you out of house and home
For as long as she holds to this way of thinking
Which the immortal gods have put in her breast.
She is building quite a reputation for herself,
But at your expense. As for us, we're staying put
Until she chooses one of the Achaeans to marry."

Telemachus, drawing a deep breath, responded:

"Antinous, I cannot throw out of my house
The mother who bore me and raised me.
As for my father, he may be alive or dead
But he is not here. It would not be fair
If I had to pay a great price to Icarius,
As I would if I sent my mother back to him
On my own initiative. And the spirits would send me
Other evils, for my mother would curse me
As she left the house, and call on the Furies.
And men all over would hold me at fault.
So I will never tell my mother to leave.
As for you, if you don't like it,
If this offends your sense of fairness,
Get out of my house! Fix yourselves feasts
In each others' houses, use up your own stockpiles.
But if it seems better and more profitable
For one man to be eaten out of house and home
Without compensation—then eat away!
But I will pray to the gods eternal
That Zeus grant me requital: Death for you
Here in my house. With no compensation."

[Lines 162–282 are omitted. The assembly continues. Telemachus announces his wish to set sail in search of news about his father. Mentor, an old friend of Odysseus, asks men of Ithaca to rebuke the suitors and is ridiculed. The assembly breaks and the suitors go off to Odysseus's house.]

Telemachus, though, went down to the shore,
Washed his hands in the surf, and prayed to Athena:

"Hear me, god of yesterday. You came to our house
And commanded me to sail the misty sea
In search of news of my long-absent father.
Now the townspeople are blocking all that,
Especially the suitors, those arrogant bastards."

He prayed, and Athena was with him,
Looking just like Mentor and with Mentor's voice.
Her words flew to Telemachus on wings:

"You won't turn out to be a fool or a coward,
Telemachus, not if any of Odysseus' spirit
Has been instilled in you. Now there was a man
Who made sure of his words and deeds! Don't worry,
You'll make this journey, and it won't be in vain.
If you're really Odysseus' and Penelope's son,
You'll finish whatever you set your mind to.
You know, few sons turn out to be like their fathers;
Most turn out worse, a few better.
No, you don't have it in you to be a fool or a coward,
And you've got something of Odysseus' brains,
So there's reason to think you'll finish this job.
Never mind, then, about the suitors' schemes.
They're mad, not an ounce of sense or justice in them,
And they have no idea of the dark death
Closing in on them, doomed all to die on a single day.
As for you, the journey you have your heart set on
Won't be delayed. I myself, your father's old comrade,
Will equip a fast ship and sail along with you.
You get the provisions and stow them aboard,
Wine in jars and barley meal in tight skins,
Food that will stick to men's ribs. I'll go through town
And round up a volunteer crew. There are plenty of ships
In Ithaca, old and new. I'll scout out the best one,
Get her rigged, and launch her onto the open sea."

Thus Athena, daughter of Zeus.

[Lines 319–365 are omitted. Telemachus goes back to his house, where the suitors are again gathered, busy slaughtering animals for another feast. They mock Telemachus for his plan to set sail for Pylos. Telemachus goes on to his father's treasure chamber to prepare provisions for his voyage.]

The close-fitting, double doors were locked,
And the room was watched day and night
By a wise old stewardess, Eurycleia,
Daughter of Ops, son of Peisenor. Telemachus
Had summoned her and now spoke to her there:

"Nurse, siphon me off some wine in jars,
The sweetest, mellowest wine we have
After what you are holding in reserve
For Odysseus, that unlucky man,
Should he ever return from the jaws of death.
Fill twelve jars and fit them with lids,
And pour some barley meal into well-sewn skins.
I'll need twenty quarts of ground barley meal.
But don't let anyone know. Just have all this
Ready to go. I'll pick it up this evening
After my mother has gone to bed upstairs.
I'm off to Sparta and to sandy Pylos
To see if I can get some news of my father."

He spoke, and Eurycleia gave a shrill cry.
She sobbed as her words went out to him:

"Ah, where did you get this idea, child?
Why would you want to travel abroad, you,
A beloved only son? Zeus-born Odysseus
Perished far from home, in a strange land.
These men, as soon as you are gone, will plot
To have you killed by treachery, and then divide
All these things among themselves. No, stay here
With what is yours. There is no need for you
To wander and suffer on the barren sea."

And Telemachus, in his cool-headed way:

"Don't worry, nurse. There is a god
Behind all this. But swear you won't say
Anything to my mother for a dozen days or so,
Or until she misses me herself or has heard
That I am gone. I don't want her crying."

And the old woman swore to the gods
That she would say nothing. That done,
She drew the wine for him in jars
And poured the barley meal into skins,
While Telemachus went back to join the suitors.

[Lines 406–446 are omitted. Assuming the form of Telemachus, Athena recruits sailors and borrows a ship from Noemon. She then comes to Telemachus looking like Mentor, and urges Telemachus to set sail. Telemachus stocks the ship with provisions and is ready for the journey.]

Telemachus called to the crew to rig the sail.
Falling to, they raised the fir mast,
Set it in its socket, braced it with forestays
And hauled up the white sail. The wind
Bellied the canvas, and an indigo wave
Hissed off the bow as the ship sped on.
When they had made all the tackle secure
In their swift black ship, they set out bowls
Brimming with wine, and poured libations
To the immortal gods, most of all
To the daughter of Zeus with seagrey eyes.

The ship bore through the night and into the dawn.

[Books 3 and 4 are omitted. Encouraged by Athena, still in the disguise of Mentor, Telemachus visits Pylos and impresses King Nestor with his speech. Nestor recalls the Greeks' journeys home after falling Troy, and tells how Agamemnon is murdered by his wife's lover and avenged by his son. Telemachus continues his travel to Sparta, where he is warmly received by King Menelaus and Helen, the wife come home. Helen speaks of Odysseus's visit to Troy disguised as a beggar while Menelaus describes his own journey home, revealing the hearsay that Odysseus is kept by Calypso on her island. In Ithaca, the suitors now plan to ambush Telemachus when he sails home.]

ODYSSEY 5

Dawn reluctantly
Left Tithonus in her rose-shadowed bed,
Then shook the morning into flakes of fire.

Light flooded the halls of Olympus
Where Zeus, high Lord of Thunder,
Sat with the other gods, listening to Athena
Reel off the tale of Odysseus' woes.
It galled her that he was still in Calypso's cave:

"Zeus, my father—and all you blessed immortals—
Kings might as well no longer be gentle and kind
Or understand the correct order of things.
They might as well be tryannical butchers
For all that any of Odysseus' people
Remember him, a godly king as kind as a father.
No, he's still languishing on that island, detained
Against his will by that nymph Calypso,
No way in the world for him to get back to his land.
His ships are all lost, he has no crew left
To row him across the sea's crawling back.
And now the islanders are plotting to kill his son
As he heads back home. He went for news of his father
To sandy Pylos and white-bricked Sparta."

Storm Cloud Zeus had an answer for her:

"Quite a little speech you've let slip through your teeth,
Daughter. But wasn't this exactly your plan
So that Odysseus would make them pay for it later?
You know how to get Telemachus
Back to Ithaca and out of harm's way
With his mother's suitors sailing in a step behind."

Zeus turned then to his son Hermes and said:

"Hermes, you've been our messenger before.
Go tell that ringleted nymph it is my will
To let that patient man Odysseus go home.
Not with an escort, mind you, human or divine,
But on a rickety raft—tribulation at sea—
Until on the twentieth day he comes to Scheria
In the land of the Phaeacians, our distant relatives,
Who will treat Odysseus as if he were a god
And take him on a ship to his own native land
With gifts of bronze and clothing and gold,
More than he ever would have taken back from Troy
Had he come home safely with his share of the loot.
That's how he's destined to see his dear ones again
And return to his high-gabled Ithacan home."

Thus Zeus, and the quicksilver messenger
Laced on his feet the beautiful sandals,
Golden, immortal, that carry him over
Landscape and seascape on a puff of wind.
And he picked up the wand he uses to charm
Mortal eyes to sleep and make sleepers awake.

Holding this wand the tough quicksilver god
Took off, bounded onto Pieria
And dove through the ether down to the sea,

Skimming the waves like a cormorant,
The bird that patrols the saltwater billows
Hunting for fish, seaspume on its plumage,

Hermes flying low and planing the whitecaps.

When he finally arrived at the distant island
He stepped from the violet-tinctured sea
On to dry land and proceeded to the cavern
Where Calypso lived. She was at home.
A fire blazed on the hearth, and the smell
Of split cedar and arbor vitae burning
Spread like incense across the whole island.
She was seated inside, singing in a lovely voice
As she wove at her loom with a golden shuttle.
Around her cave the woodland was in bloom,
Alder and poplar and fragrant cypress.
Long-winged birds nested in the leaves,
Horned owls and larks and slender-throated shorebirds
That screech like crows over the bright saltwater.
Tendrils of ivy curled around the cave's mouth,
The glossy green vine clustered with berries.
Four separate springs flowed with clear water, criss-
Crossing channels as they meandered through meadows
Lush with parsley and blossoming violets.
It was enough to make even a visiting god
Enraptured at the sight. Quicksilver Hermes
Took it all in, then turned and entered
The vast cave.
Calypso knew him at sight.
The immortals have ways of recognizing each other,
Even those whose homes are in outlying districts.
But Hermes didn't find the great hero inside.
Odysseus was sitting on the shore,
As ever those days, honing his heart's sorrow,
Staring out to sea with hollow, salt-rimmed eyes.

Calypso, sleek and haloed, questioned Hermes
Politely, as she seated him on a lacquered chair:

"My dear Hermes, to what do I owe
The honor of this unexpected visit? Tell me
What you want, and I'll oblige you if I can."

The goddess spoke, and then set a table
With ambrosia and mixed a bowl of rosy nectar.

The quicksilver messenger ate and drank his fill,
Then settled back from dinner with heart content
And made the speech she was waiting for:

"You ask me, goddess to god, why I have come.
Well, I'll tell you exactly why. Remember, you asked.
Zeus ordered me to come here; I didn't want to.
Who would want to cross this endless stretch
Of deserted sea? Not a single city in sight
Where you can get a decent sacrifice from men.
But you know how it is: Zeus has the aegis,
And none of us gods can oppose his will.
He says you have here the most woebegone hero
Of the whole lot who fought around Priam's city
For nine years, sacked it in the tenth, and started home.
But on the way back they offended Athena,
And she swamped them with hurricane winds and waves.
His entire crew was wiped out, and he
Drifted along until he was washed up here.
Anyway, Zeus wants you to send him back home. Now.
The man's not fated to rot here far from his friends.
It's his destiny to see his dear ones again
And return to his high-gabled Ithacan home."

He finished, and the nymph's aura stiffened.
Words flew from her mouth like screaming hawks:

"You gods are the most jealous bastards in the universe—
Persecuting any goddess who ever openly takes
A mortal lover to her bed and sleeps with him.
When Dawn caressed Orion with her rosy fingers,
You celestial layabouts gave her nothing but trouble
Until Artemis finally shot him on Ortygia—
Gold-throned, holy, gentle-shafted assault goddess!
When Demeter followed her heart and unbound
Her hair for Iasion and made love to him
In a late-summer field, Zeus was there taking notes
And executed the man with a cobalt lightning blast.
And now you gods are after me for having a man.
Well, I was the one who saved his life, unprying him

From the spar he came floating here on, sole survivor
Of the wreck Zeus made of his streamlined ship,
Slivering it with lightning on the wine-dark sea.
I loved him, I took care of him, I even told him
I'd make him immortal and ageless all of his days.
But you said it, Hermes: Zeus has the aegis
And none of us gods can oppose his will.
So all right, he can go, if it's an order from above,
Off on the sterile sea. How I don't know.
I don't have any oared ships or crewmen
To row him across the sea's broad back.
But I'll help him. I'll do everything I can
To get him back safely to his own native land."

The quicksilver messenger had one last thing to say:

"Well send him off now and watch out for Zeus' temper.
Cross him and he'll really be rough on you later."

With that the tough quicksilver god made his exit.

Calypso composed herself and went to Odysseus,
Zeus' message still ringing in her ears.
She found him sitting where the breakers rolled in.
His eyes were perpetually wet with tears now,
His life draining away in homesickness.
The nymph had long since ceased to please.
He still slept with her at night in her cavern,
An unwilling lover mated to her eager embrace.
Days he spent sitting on the rocks by the breakers,
Staring out to sea with hollow, salt-rimmed eyes.
She stood close to him and started to speak:

"You poor man. You can stop grieving now
And pining away. I'm sending you home.
Look, here's a bronze axe. Cut some long timbers
And make yourself a raft fitted with topdecks,
Something that will get you across the sea's misty spaces.
I'll stock it with fresh water, food and red wine—
Hearty provisions that will stave off hunger—and

I'll clothe you well and send you a following wind
To bring you home safely to your own native land,
If such is the will of the gods of high heaven,
Whose minds and powers are stronger than mine."

Odysseus' eyes shone with weariness. He stiffened,
And shot back at her words fletched like arrows:

"I don't know what kind of send-off you have in mind,
Goddess, telling me to cross all that open sea on a raft,
Painful, hard sailing. Some well-rigged vessels
Never make it across with a stiff wind from Zeus.
You're not going to catch me setting foot on any raft
Unless you agree to swear a solemn oath
That you're not planning some new trouble for me."

Calypso's smile was like a shower of light.
She touched him gently, and teased him a little:

"Blasphemous, that's what you are—but nobody's fool!
How do you manage to say things like that?
All right. I swear by Earth and Heaven above
And the subterranean water of Styx—the greatest
Oath and the most awesome a god can swear—
That I'm not planning more trouble for you, Odysseus.
I'll put my mind to work for you as hard as I would
For myself, if ever I were in such a fix.
My heart is in the right place, Odysseus,
Nor is it a cold lump of iron in my breast."

With that the haloed goddess walked briskly away
And the man followed in the deity's footsteps.
The two forms, human and divine, came to the cave
And he sat down in the chair which moments before
Hermes had vacated, and the nymph set out for him
Food and drink such as mortal men eat.
She took a seat opposite godlike Odysseus
And her maids served her ambrosia and nectar.
They helped themselves to as much as they wanted,
And when they had their fill of food and drink

Calypso spoke, an immortal radiance upon her:

"Son of Laertes in the line of Zeus, my wily Odysseus,
Do you really want to go home to your beloved country
Right away? Now? Well, you still have my blessings.
But if you had any idea of all the pain
You're destined to suffer before getting home,
You'd stay here with me, deathless—
Think of it, Odysseus!—no matter how much
You missed your wife and wanted to see her again.
You spend all your daylight hours yearning for her.
I don't mind saying she's not my equal
In beauty, no matter how you measure it.
Mortal beauty cannot compare with immortal."

Odysseus, always thinking, answered her this way:

"Goddess and mistress, don't be angry with me.
I know very well that Penelope,
For all her virtues, would pale beside you.
She's only human, and you are a goddess,
Eternally young. Still, I want to go back.
My heart aches for the day I return to my home.
If some god hits me hard as I sail the deep purple,
I'll weather it like the sea-bitten veteran I am.
God knows I've suffered and had my share of sorrows
In war and at sea. I can take more if I have to."

The sun set on his words, and the shadows darkened.
They went to a room deep in the cave, where they made
Sweet love and lay side by side through the night.

Dawn came early, touching the sky with rose.

Odysseus put on a shirt and cloak,
And the nymph slipped on a long silver robe
Shimmering in the light, cinched it at the waist
With a golden belt and put a veil on her head.
What to do about sending Odysseus off?
She handed him an axe, bronze, both edges honed.

The olive-wood haft felt good in his palms.
She gave him a sharp adze, too, then led the way
To the island's far side where the trees grew tall,
Alder and poplar and silver fir, sky-topping trees
Long-seasoned and dry that would keep him afloat.
Calypso showed him where the trees grew tall
Then went back home, a glimmer in the woods,
While Odysseus cut timber.
Working fast,
He felled twenty trees, cut them to length,
Smoothed them skillfully and trued them to the line.
The glimmer returned—Calypso with an auger—
And he drilled the beams through, fit them up close
And hammered them together with joiners and pegs.
About the size of a deck a master shipwright
Chisels into shape for a broad-bowed freighter
Was the size Odysseus made his wide raft.
He fit upright ribs close-set in the decking
And finished them with long facing planks.
He built a mast and fit in a yardarm,
And he made a rudder to steer her by.
Then he wove a wicker-work barrier
To keep off the waves, plaiting it thick.
Calypso brought him a large piece of cloth
To make into a sail, and he fashioned that, too.
He rigged up braces and halyards and lines,
Then levered his craft down to the glittering sea.

Day four, and the job was finished.
Day five, and Calypso saw him off her island,
After she had bathed him and dressed him
In fragrant clothes. She filled up a skin
With wine that ran black, another large one
With water, and tucked into a duffel
A generous supply of hearty provisions.
And she put a breeze at his back, gentle and warm.

Odysseus' heart sang as he spread sail to the wind,
And he steered with the rudder, a master mariner

Aboard his craft. Sleep never fell on his eyelids
As he watched the Pleiades and slow-setting Boötes
And the Bear (also known as the Wagon)
That pivots in place and chases Orion
And alone is aloof from the wash of Ocean.
Calypso, the glimmering goddess, had told him
To sail with the stars of the Bear on his left.
Seventeen days he sailed the deep water,
And on the eighteenth day the shadowy mountains
Of the Phaeacians' land loomed on the horizon,
To his eyes like a shield on the misty sea.

[Lines 282–502 are omitted. Coming back from Ethiopia, Poseidon is enraged to find Odysseus sailing on the sea. He raises a big storm that destroys the raft and throws the man overboard. After much struggle in the open sea, Odysseus reaches dry land with the help of the goddesses Ino and Athena.]

[Books 6 to 15 are omitted. Odysseus is discovered by Nausicaa, daughter of King Alcinous, who rules the land where Odysseus finds himself. With the help of Nausicaa, Odysseus wins the king's favour and the offer of a safe passage home. Odysseus entertains the king by recounting his adventures in the last ten years. Impressed by Odysseus's storytelling, Alcinous honours his promise and has his men escort Odysseus to Ithaca. Athena appears before Odysseus, now back in his homeland, and makes him look like an old beggar. In the new disguise, Odysseus visits his swineherd to find out about the situation at home. Meanwhile, Athena goes to Sparta and instructs Telemachus to go home by a route safe from the suitors' ambush. She also tells him to go to the swineherd instead of going home in the city.]

ODYSSEY 16

Meanwhile, in the hut, Odysseus
And the noble swineherd had kindled a fire

And were making breakfast in the early light.
They had already sent the herdsmen out
With the droves of swine.
The dogs fawned
Around Telemachus and did not bark at him
As he approached. Odysseus noticed
The dogs fawning and heard footsteps.
His words flew fast to Eumaeus:

"Eumaeus, one of your men must be coming,
Or at least someone you know. The dogs aren't barking
And are fawning around him. I can hear his footsteps."

His words weren't out when his own son
Stood in the doorway. Up jumped the swineherd
In amazement, and from his hands fell the vessels
He was using to mix the wine. He went
To greet his master, kissing his head
And his shining eyes and both his hands.

And as a loving father embraces his own son
Come back from a distant land after ten long years,
His only son, greatly beloved and much sorrowed for—

So did the noble swineherd clasp Telemachus
And kiss him all over—he had escaped from death—
And sobbing he spoke to him these winged words:

"You have come, Telemachus, sweet light!
I thought I would never see you again
After you left in your ship for Pylos. But come in,
Dear child, let me feast my eyes on you
Here in my house, come back from abroad!
You don't visit the farm often, or us herdsmen,
But stay in town. It must do your heart good
To look at that weeviling crowd of suitors."

And Telemachus, in his clear-headed way:

"Have it your way, Papa. But it's for your sake I've come,
To see you with my own eyes, and to hear from you
Whether my mother is still in our house,
Or someone else has married her by now,
And Odysseus' bed, with no one to sleep in it,
Has become a nest of spider webs."

The swineherd answered him:

"Yes, she's in your house, waiting and waiting
With an enduring heart, poor soul,
Weeping away the lonely days and nights."

He spoke, and took the young man's spear.
Telemachus went in, and as he crossed
The stone threshold, Odysseus stood up
To offer him his seat, but Telemachus,
From across the room, checked him and said:

"Keep your seat, stranger. We'll find another one
Around the place. Eumaeus here can do that."

[Lines 51–164 are omitted. Odysseus, still speaking as a stranger, makes Telemachus talk about the suitors and his family. Telemachus sends the swineherd off to tell Penelope and nobody else that he is safe and back.]

The swineherd's departure
Was not unnoticed by Athena. She approached
The farmstead in the likeness of a woman,
Beautiful, tall, and accomplished in handiwork,
And stood in the doorway of Eumaeus' hut,
Showing herself to Odysseus. Telemachus
Did not see her before him or notice her presence,
For the gods are not visible to everyone.
But Odysseus saw her, and the dogs did, too,
And they did not bark, but slunk away whining
To the other side of the farmstead. The goddess
Lifted her brows, and Odysseus understood.

He went out of the hut, past the courtyard's great wall,
And stood before her. Athena said to him:

"Son of Laertes in the line of Zeus,
Tell your son now and do not keep him in the dark,
So that you two can plan the suitors' destruction
And then go into town. As for myself,
I will not be gone long. No, I am eager for battle."

With this, she touched him with her golden wand.
A fresh tunic and cloak replaced his rags,
And he was taller and younger, his skin tanned,
His jawline firm, and his beard glossy black.
Having worked her magic, the goddess left,
And Odysseus went back into the hut.
His son was astounded. Shaken and flustered,
He turned away his eyes for fear it was a god,
And words fell from his lips in nervous flurries:

"You look different, stranger, than you did before,
And your clothes are different, and your complexion.
You must be a god, one of the immortals
Who hold high heaven. Be gracious to us
So we can offer you acceptable sacrifice
And finely wrought gold. And spare us, please."

And godlike Odysseus, who had borne much:

"I am no god. Why liken me to the deathless ones?
No, I am your father, on whose account you have suffered
Many pains and endured the violence of men."

Saying this, he kissed his son, and let his tears
Fall to the ground. He had held them in until now.
But Telemachus could not believe
That this was his father, and he blurted out:

"You cannot be my father Odysseus.

You must be some spirit, enchanting me
Only to increase my grief and pain later.
No mortal man could figure out how to do this
All on his own. Only a god could so easily
Transform someone from old to young.
A while ago you were old and shabbily dressed,
And now you are like the gods who hold high heaven."

And Odysseus, from his mind's teeming depths:

"Telemachus, it does not become you to be so amazed
That your father is here in this house. You can be sure
That no other Odysseus will ever come.
But I am here, just as you see, home at last
After twenty years of suffering and wandering.
So you will know, this is Athena's doing.
She can make me look like whatever she wants:
A beggar sometimes, and sometimes a young man
Wearing fine clothes. It's easy for the gods
To glorify a man or to make him look poor."

He spoke, and sat down. And Telemachus
Threw his arms around his wonderful father
And wept. And a longing arose in both of them
To weep and lament, and their shrill cries
Crowded the air

like the cries of birds—
Sea-eagles or taloned vultures—
Whose young chicks rough farmers have stolen
Out of their nests before they were fledged.

Their tears were that piteous. And the sun,
Its light fading, would have set on their weeping,
Had not Telemachus suddenly said to his father:

"What ship brought you here, Father,
And where did the crew say they were from?

I don't suppose you came here on foot."

And Odysseus, the godlike survivor:

"I'll tell you the truth about this, son.
The Phaeacians brought me, famed sailors
Who give passage to all who come their way.
They brought me over the sea as I slept
In their swift ship, and set me ashore on Ithaca
With donations of bronze and clothing and gold,
Splendid treasures that are now stored in caves
By grace of the gods. I have come here now
At Athena's suggestion. You and I must plan
How to kill our enemies. List them for me now
So I can know who they are, and how many,
And so I can weigh the odds and decide whether
You and I can go up against them alone
Or whether we have to enlist some allies."

Telemachus took a deep breath and said:

"Father, look now, I know your great reputation,
How you can handle a spear and what a strategist you are,
But this is too much for me. Two men
Simply cannot fight against such superior numbers
And superior force. There are not just ten suitors,
Or twice that, but many times more. Here's the count:
From Dulichium there are fifty-two—
The pick of their young men—and six attendants.
From Samê there are twenty-four,
From Zacynthus there are twenty,
And from Ithaca itself, twelve, all the noblest,
And with them are Medon the herald,
The divine bard, and two attendants who carve.
If we go up against all of them in the hall,
I fear your vengeance will be bitter indeed.
Please try to think of someone to help us,
Someone who would gladly be our ally."

And Odysseus, who had borne much:

"I'll tell you who will help. Do you think
That Athena and her father, Zeus,
Would be help enough? Or should I think of more?"

Telemachus answered in his clear-headed way:

"You're talking about two excellent allies,
Although they do sit a little high in the clouds
And have to rule the whole world and the gods as well."

And Odysseus, who had borne much:

"Those two won't hold back from battle for long.
They'll be here, all right, when the fighting starts
Between the suitors and us in my high-roofed halls.
For now, go at daybreak up to the house,
And keep company with these insolent hangers-on.
The swineherd will lead me to the city later
Looking like an old, broken-down beggar.
If they treat me badly in the house,
Just endure it. Even if they drag me
Through the door by my feet, or throw things at me,
Just bear it patiently. Try to dissuade them,
Try to talk them out of their folly, sure,
But they won't listen to you at all,
Because their day of reckoning is near.
And here's something else for you to keep in mind:
When Athena in her wisdom prompts me,
I'll give you a signal. When you see me nod,
Take all the weapons that are in the hall
Into the lofted storeroom and stow them there.
When the suitors miss them and ask you
Where they are, set their minds at ease, saying:
'Oh, I have stored them out of the smoke.
They're nothing like they were when Odysseus
Went off to Troy, but are all grimed with soot.
Also, a god put this thought into my head,
That when you men are drinking, you might
Start quarreling and someone could get hurt,
Which would ruin your feasting and courting.

Steel has a way of drawing a man to it.'
But leave behind a couple of swords for us,
And two spears and oxhide shields—leave them
Where we can get to them in a hurry.
Pallas Athena and Zeus in his cunning
Will keep the suitors in a daze for a while.
And one more thing before you go.
If you are really my son and have my blood
In your veins, don't let anyone know
That Odysseus is at home—not Laertes,
Not the swineherd, not anyone in the house,
Not even Penelope. You and I by ourselves
Will figure out which way the women are leaning.
We'll test more than one of the servants, too,
And see who respects us and fears us,
And who cares nothing about either one of us
And fails to honor you. You're a man now."

And Odysseus' resplendent son answered:

"You'll soon see what I'm made of, Father,
And I don't think you'll find me lacking.
But I'm not sure your plan will work
To our advantage. Think about it.
It'll take forever for you to make the rounds
Testing each man, while back in the house
The high-handed suitors are having a good time
Eating their way through everything we own.
I agree you should find out which of the women
Dishonor you, and which are innocent.
But as for testing the men in the fields,
Let's do that afterward, if indeed you know
Something from Zeus, who holds the aegis."

[Lines 340–517 are omitted. The ship that Telemachus has sailed in reaches the Ithacan port. A herald announces Telemachus's return, unaware of his wish to keep it a secret. The suitors scheme on the next move suggesting to kill Telemachus. On the other hand, the swineherd tells Penelope of the suitors' earlier ambush plot. She confronts Antinous about it.]

[Books 17 and 18 are omitted. Telemachus goes home to Penelope, relating to her what he hears in Pylos and Sparta, including Odysseus's detention in Calypso's island. Odysseus arrives later with the swineherd as an old beggar. He begs among the suitors to test them out for decency. He is insulted by another beggar, his own servants as well as the suitors Antinous and Eurymachus. Penelope shows herself to the suitors and creates a big stir, and more nasty words are directed at Odysseus.]

ODYSSEY 19

So Odysseus was left alone in the hall,
Planning death for the suitors with Athena's aid.
He spoke winged words to Telemachus:

"Telemachus, get all the weapons out of the hall.
When the suitors miss them and ask you
Where they are, set their minds at ease, saying:
'Oh, I have stored them out of the smoke.
They're nothing like they were when Odysseus
Went off to Troy, but are all grimed with soot.
Also, a god put this thought into my head,
That when you men are drinking, you might
Start quarreling and someone could get hurt,
Which would ruin your feasting and courting.
Steel has a way of drawing a man to it.'"

Thus Odysseus. Telemachus nodded,
And calling Eurycleia he said to her:

"Nurse, shut the women inside their rooms
While I put my father's weapons away,
The beautiful weapons left out in the hall
And dulled by the smoke since he went off to war.

I was just a child then. But now I want
To store them away, safe from the smoke."

And Eurycleia, his old nurse, said:

"Yes, child, you are right
To care for the house and guard its wealth.
But who will fetch a light and carry it for you,
Since you won't let any of the women do it?"

Telemachus coolly answered her:

"This stranger here. I won't let anyone
Who gets rations be idle, even a traveler
From a distant land."

Telemachus' words sank in,
And the nurse locked the doors of the great hall.
Odysseus and his illustrious son sprang up
And began storing away the helmets, bossed shields,
And honed spears. And before them Pallas Athena,
Bearing a golden lamp, made a beautiful light.
Telemachus suddenly blurted out to his father:

"Father, this is a miracle I'm seeing!
The walls of the house, the lovely panels,
The beams of fir, and the high columns
Are glowing like fire. Some god is inside,
One of the gods from the open sky."

Odysseus, his mind teeming, replied:

"Hush. Don't be too curious about this.
This is the way of the gods who hold high heaven.
Go get some rest. I'll remain behind here
And draw out the maids—and your mother,
Who in her grief will ask many questions."

And Telemachus went out through the hall

By the light of blazing torches. He came
To his room, lay down, and waited for dawn.
Odysseus again was alone in the hall,
Planning death for the suitors with Athena's aid.

Penelope, wary and thoughtful,
Now came from her bedroom, and she was like
Artemis or golden Aphrodite.
They set a chair for her by the fire
Where she always sat, a chair inlaid
With spiraling ivory and silver
Which the craftsman Icmalius had made long ago.
It had a footstool attached, covered now
With a thick fleece.
Penelope sat down,
Taking everything in. White-armed maids
Came out from the women's quarters
And started to take away all of the food,
Clearing the tables and picking up the cups
From which the men had been drinking.
They emptied the braziers, scattering the embers
Onto the floor, and then stocked them up
With loads of fresh wood for warmth and light.

Then Melantho started in on Odysseus again:

"Are we going to have to put up with you all night,
Roaming through the house and spying on the women?
Go on outside and be glad you had supper,
Or you'll soon stagger out struck with a torch."

And Odysseus answered from his teeming mind:

"What's wrong with you, woman? Are you mean to me
Because I'm dirty and dressed in rags
And beg through the land? I do it because I have to.
That's how it is with beggars and vagabonds.
You know, I too once lived in a house in a city,
A rich man in a wealthy house, and I often gave

Gifts to wanderers, whatever they needed.
I had servants, too, countless servants,
And plenty of everything else a man needs
To live the good life and be considered wealthy.
But Zeus crushed me. Who knows why?
So be careful, woman. Someday you may lose
That glowing beauty that makes you stand out now.
Or your mistress may become fed up with you.
Or Odysseus may come. We can still hope for that.
But even if, as seems likely, he is dead
And will never return, his son, Telemachus,
Is now very much like him, by Apollo's grace,
And if any of the women are behaving loosely
It won't get by him. He's no longer a child."

None of this was lost on Penelope,
And she scolded the maidservant, saying:

"Your outrageous conduct does not escape me,
Shameless whore that you are, and it will be
On your own head. You knew very well,
For you heard me say it, that I intended
To question the stranger here in my halls
About my husband; for I am sick with worry."

Then to Eurynome, the housekeeper, she said:

"Bring a chair here with a fleece upon it
So that the stranger can sit down and tell his tale
And listen to me. I have many questions for him."

So Eurynome brought up a polished chair
And threw a fleece over it, and upon it sat
Odysseus, patient and godlike.
Penelope, watchful, began with a question:

"First, stranger, let me ask you this:
Who are you and where are you from?"

Odysseus, his mind teeming, answered her:

"Lady, no one on earth could find fault with you,
For your fame reaches the heavens above,
Just like the fame of a blameless king,
A godfearing man who rules over thousands
Of valiant men, upholding justice.
His rich, black land bears barley and wheat,
The trees are laden with fruit, the flocks
Are always with young, and the sea teems with fish—
Because he rules well, and so his people prosper.
Ask me, therefore, about anything else,
But not about my birth or my native land.
That would fill my heart with painful memories.
I have many sorrows, and it wouldn't be right
To sit here weeping in another's house,
Nor is it good to be constantly grieving.
I don't want one of your maids, or you yourself,
To be upset with me and say I am awash with tears
Because the wine has gone to my head."

And Penelope, watching, answered him:

"Stranger, the gods destroyed my beauty
On the day when the Argives sailed for Ilion
And with them went my husband, Odysseus.
If he were to come back and be part of my life,
My fame would be greater and more resplendent so.
But now I ache, so many sorrows
Has some spirit showered upon me.
All of the nobles who rule the islands—
Dulichium, Samê, wooded Zacynthus—
And all those with power on rocky Ithaca
Are courting me and ruining this house.
So I pay no attention to strangers
Or to suppliants or public heralds. No,
I just waste away with longing for Odysseus.
My suitors press on, and I weave my wiles.

First some god breathed into me the thought
Of setting up a great loom in the main hall,
And I started weaving a vast fabric
With a very fine thread, and I said to them:

'Young men—my suitors, since Odysseus is dead—
Eager as you are to marry me, you must wait
Until I finish this robe—it would be a shame
To waste my spinning—a shroud for the hero
Laertes, when death's doom lays him low.
I fear the Achaean women would reproach me
If he should lie in death shroudless for all his wealth.'
"So I spoke, and their proud hearts consented.
Every day I would weave at the great loom,
And every night unweave the web by torchlight.
I fooled them for three years with my craft.
But in the fourth year, as the seasons rolled by,
And the moons waned, and the days dragged on,
My shameless and headstrong serving women
Betrayed me. The men barged in and caught me at it,
And a howl went up. So I was forced to finish the shroud.
Now I can't escape the marriage. I'm at my wit's end.
My parents are pressing me to marry,
And my son agonizes over the fact
That these men are devouring his inheritance.
He is a man now, and able to preside
Over a household to which Zeus grants honor.
But tell me of your birth, for you are not sprung,
As the saying goes, from stock or stone."

[Lines 178–223 are omitted. Odysseus makes up a story about his identity, saying he comes from the island of Crete, where he once received Odysseus as a guest, when Odysseus was blown off course on his way to Troy. It is all lies, but Odysseus tells them as if they were true.]

So her lovely cheeks coursed with tears as she wept
For her husband, who was sitting before her.
Odysseus pitied her tears in his heart,
But his eyes were as steady between their lids

As if they were made of horn or iron
As he concealed his own tears through guile.
When Penelope had cried herself out,
She spoke to him again, saying:

"Now I feel I must test you, stranger,
To see if you really did entertain my husband
And his godlike companions, as you say you did.
Tell me what sort of clothes he wore, and tell me
What he was like, and what his men were like."

And Odysseus, from his mind's teeming depths:

"Lady, it is difficult for me to speak
After we've been apart for so long. It has been
Twenty years since he left my country.
But I have an image of him in my mind.
Odysseus wore a fleecy purple cloak,
Folded over, and it had a brooch
With a double clasp, fashioned of gold,
And on the front was an intricate design:
A hound holding in his forepaws a dappled fawn
That writhed to get free. Everyone marveled
At how, though it was all made of gold,
The hound had his eye fixed on the fawn
As he was strangling it, and the fawn
Twisted and struggled to get to its feet.
And I remember the tunic he wore,
Glistening like onionskin, soft and shiny
And with a sheen like sunlight. There were
Quite a few women who admired it.
But remember, now, I do not know
Whether Odysseus wore this at home,
Or whether one of his men gave it to him
When he boarded ship, or someone else,
For Odysseus was a man with many friends.
He had few equals among the Achaeans.
I, too, gave him gifts—a bronze sword,
A beautiful purple cloak, and a fringed tunic,

And I gave him a ceremonious send-off
In his benched ship. And one more thing:
He had a herald, a little older than he was,
And I will tell you what he looked like.
He was slope-shouldered, with dark skin
And curly hair. His name was Eurybates,
And Odysseus held him in higher esteem
Than his other men, because they thought alike."

These words stirred up Penelope's grief.
She recognized the unmistakeable tokens
Odysseus was giving her. She wept again,
And then composed herself and said to him:

"You may have been pitied before, stranger,
But now you will be loved and honored
Here in my halls. I gave him those clothes.
I folded them, brought them from the storeroom,
And pinned on the gleaming brooch,
To delight him. But I will never welcome him
Home again, and so the fates were dark
When Odysseus left in his hollow ship
For Ilion, that curse of a city."

And Odysseus, from his mind's teeming depths:

"Revered wife of Laertes' son, Odysseus,
Do not mar your fair skin with tears any more,
Or melt your heart with weeping for your husband.
Not that I blame you. Any woman weeps
When she has lost her husband, a man with whom
She has made love and whose children she has borne—
And the husband you've lost is Odysseus,
Who they say is like the immortal gods.
Stop weeping, though, and listen to my words,
For what I am about to tell you is true.
I have lately heard of Odysseus' return,
That he is near, in the rich land of Thesprotia,
Still alive. And he is bringing home treasures,

Seeking gifts, and getting them, throughout the land.
But he lost his trusty crew and his hollow ship
On the wine-dark sea. As he was sailing out
From the island of Thrinacia, Zeus and Helios
Hit him hard because his companions had killed
The cattle of the Sun. His men went under,
But he rode his ship's keel until the waves
Washed him ashore in the land of the Phaeacians,
Whose race is closely akin to the gods'.
They treated him as if he were a god,
Gave him many gifts, and were more than willing
To escort him home. And he would have been here
By now, but he thought it more profitable
To gather wealth by roaming the land.
No one is as good as Odysseus
At finding ways to gain an advantage.
I had all this from Pheidon, the Thesprotian king.
And he swore to me, as he poured libations
There in his house, that a ship was already launched,
And a crew standing by, to take him home.
He sent me off first, since a Thesprotian ship
Happened to be leaving for Dulichium,
But before I left, Pheidon showed me
All the treasure Odysseus had amassed,
Bronze, gold, and wrought iron, enough to feed
His children's children for ten generations,
All stored there for him in the halls of the king.
Odysseus, he said, had gone to Dodona
To consult the oak-tree oracle of Zeus
And ask how he should return to Ithaca—
Openly or in secret—after being gone so long.
So he is safe, and will come soon.
He is very near, and will not be away long
From his dear ones and his native land.
I will swear to this. Now Zeus on high
Be my witness, and this hospitable table,
And the hearth of flawless Odysseus himself—
That everything will happen just as I say:
Before this month is out Odysseus will come,

In the dark of the moon, before the new crescent."

And Penelope, watching him carefully:

"Ah, stranger, may your words come true.
Then you would know my kindness, and my gifts
Would make you blessed in all men's eyes.
But I know in my heart that Odysseus
Will never come home, and that you will never
Find passage elsewhere, since there is not now
Any master in the house like Odysseus—
If he ever existed—to send honored guests
Safely on their way, or to welcome them.
But still, wash our guest's feet, maidens,
And prepare a bed for him. Set up a frame
And cover it with cloaks and lustrous blankets
To keep him cozy and warm. When golden Dawn
Shows her first light, bathe him and anoint him,
So he can sit side by side with Telemachus
And share in the feast here in the hall.
And anyone who causes this man any pain
Will regret it sorely and will accomplish nothing
Here in this house, however angry he gets.
For how would you ever find out, stranger,
Whether or not I surpass all other women
In presence of mind, if you sit down to dinner
Squalid and disheveled here in my hall?
Our lives are short. A hard-hearted man
Is cursed while he lives and reviled in death.
But a good-hearted man has his fame spread
Far and wide by the guests he has honored,
And men speak well of him all over the earth."

And Odysseus, his mind teeming, answered her:

"Revered wife of Odysseus, Laertes' son,
I lost all interest in cloaks and blankets
On the day I left the snowy mountains of Crete
In my long-oared ship. I will lie down tonight,

As I have through many a sleepless night,
On a poor bed, waiting for golden-throned Dawn.
Nor do I have any taste for foot-baths,
And none of the serving women here in your hall
Will touch my feet, unless there is some old,
Trustworthy woman who has suffered as I have.
I would not mind if she touched my feet."

And Penelope, watching him carefully:

"Of all the travelers who have come to my house,
None, dear guest, have been as thoughtful as you
And none as welcome, so wise are your words.
I do have an old and trustworthy woman here,
Who nursed and raised my ill-starred husband,
Taking him in her arms the day he was born.
She will wash your feet, frail as she is.
Eurycleia, rise and wash your master's—that is,
Wash the feet of this man who is your master's age.
Odysseus' feet and hands are no doubt like his now,
For men age quickly when life is hard."

At this, the old woman hid her face in her hands.
Shedding warm tears, she spoke through her sobs:

"My lost child, I can do nothing for you.
Zeus must have hated you above all other men,
Although you were always godfearing. No one
Burned more offerings to the Lord of Lightning,
So many fat thighbones, bulls by the hundreds,
With prayers that you reach a sleek old age
And raise your glorious son. And now the god has
Deprived you alone of your day of return.
And I suppose, stranger, women mocked him, too,
When he came to some man's gloried house
In a distant land, just as these cheeky bitches
All mock you here. It is to avoid their insults
That you will not allow them to wash your feet.
But Penelope, Icarius' wise daughter,

Has asked me to do it, and I will,
For her sake and for yours,
For my heart is throbbing with sorrow.
But listen now to what I have to say.
Many road-weary strangers have come here,
But I have never seen such a resemblance
As that between you and Odysseus,
In looks, voice—even the shape of your feet."

And Odysseus, from his mind's teeming depths:

"Oh, everyone who has seen us both says that,
Old woman, that we are very much alike,
Just as you yourself have noticed."

And the old woman took the shining basin
She used for washing feet, poured
Cold water into it, and then added the hot.

[Lines 423–551 are omitted. Eurycleia is washing Odysseus's feet when she notices an old scar on his thigh, which betrays his identity. Odysseus got it as a boy when he was hunting a boar with his grandfather. The old nurse wants to tell Penelope of her discovery, but Odysseus stops her from doing so while Athena diverts Penelope's mind.]

When she had washed him and rubbed on oil,
Odysseus pulled his chair close to the fire again
To keep warm, and hid the scar with his rags.

Penelope now resumed their talk:

"There's one more thing I want to ask you about,
And then it will be time to get some sleep—
At least for those to whom sweet sleep comes
Despite their cares. But some god has given me
Immeasurable sorrow. By day
I console myself with lamentation
And see to my work and that of my women.
But at night, when sleep takes hold of others,

I lie in bed, smothered by my own anxiety,
Mourning restlessly, my heart racing.
Just as the daughter of Pandareus,
The pale nightingale, sings sweetly
In the greening of spring, perched in the leaves,
And trills out her song of lament for her son,
Her beloved Itylus, whom she killed unwittingly,
Itylus, the son of Zethus her lord—
So too my heart is torn with dismay.
Should I stay here with my son
And keep everything safe and just as it is,
My goods, my slaves, my high-gabled house,
Honoring my husband's bed and public opinion—
Or should I go with whoever is best
Of all my suitors, and gives me gifts past counting?
And then there's my son. While he was young
And not yet mature, he kept me from leaving
My husband's house and marrying another.
But now that he's grown and come into manhood,
He begs me to leave, worried because
These Achaean men are devouring his goods.
But listen now to a dream I had
And tell me what it means. In my dream
I have twenty geese at home. I love to watch them
Come out of the water and eat grains of wheat.
But a huge eagle with a hooked beak comes
Down from the mountain and breaks their necks,
Killing them all. They lie strewn through the hall.
While he rides the wind up to the bright sky.
I weep and wail, still in my dream,
And Achaean ladies gather around me
As I grieve because the eagle killed my geese.
Then the eagle comes back and perches upon
A jutting roofbeam and speaks to me
In a human voice, telling me not to cry:

'Take heart, daughter of famed Icarius.
This is no dream, but a true vision
That you can trust. The geese are the suitors,

And I, who was once an eagle, am now
Your husband come back, and I will deal out doom,
A grisly death for all of the suitors.'

"So he spoke, and I woke up refreshed.
Looking around I saw the geese in the house,
Feeding on wheat by the trough, as before."

And Odysseus, his mind teeming:

"Lady, there is no way to give this dream
Another slant. Odysseus himself has shown you
How he will finish this business. The suitors' doom
Is clear. Not one will escape death's black birds."

And Penelope, in her circumspect way:

"Stranger, you should know that dreams
Are hard to interpret, and don't always come true.
There are two gates for dreams to drift through,
One made of horn and the other of ivory.
Dreams that pass through the gate of ivory
Are deceptive dreams and will not come true,
But when someone has a dream that has passed
Through the gate of polished horn, that dream
Will come true. My strange dream, though,
Did not come from there. If it had,
It would have been welcome to me and my child.
One more thing, and, please, take it to heart.
Dawn is coming, the accursed dawn of the day
Which will sever me from the house of Odysseus.
I will announce a contest. Odysseus
Used to line up axes inside his hall,
Twelve of them, like the curved chocks
That prop up a ship when it is being built,
And he would stand far off and send an arrow
Whizzing through them all. I will propose
This contest to my suitors, and whoever
Can bend that bow and slip the string on its notch

And shoot an arrow through all twelve axes,
With him will I go, leaving behind this house
I was married in, this beautiful, prosperous house,
Which I will remember always, even in my dreams."

And Odysseus, from the depths of his teeming mind:

"Revered wife of Laertes' son, Odysseus,
Do not put off this contest any longer,
For Odysseus will be here, with all his cunning,
Handling that polished bow, before these men
Could ever string it and shoot through the iron."

Then Penelope, still watching him:

"If you were willing, stranger, to sit here
Beside me in my halls and give me joy,
Sleep would never settle upon my eyes.
But we cannot always be sleepless,
For every thing there is a season, and a time
For all we do on the life-giving earth.
I will go now to my room upstairs
And lie on my bed, which has become
A sorrowful bed, wet with my tears
Since the day Odysseus left
For Ilion, that accursed city.
I will lie there, but you can lie here
In the hall. Spread some blankets on the floor,
Or have the maids make up a bed for you."

Saying this, Penelope went upstairs
To her softly lit room, not alone,
For her women went up with her.
Once in her room she wept for Odysseus,
Her beloved husband, wept until Athena
Let sweet sleep settle upon her eyelids.

[Book 20 is omitted. Odysseus spends a night in his palace and wakes up to suffer more humiliations from the goatherd and the suitors, one of whom

hurling an ox's hoof at him. But Odysseus also finds comfort in the kindness of the swineherd and the cowherd.]

ODYSSEY 21

Owl-eyed Athena now prompted Penelope
To set before the suitors Odysseus' bow
And the grey iron, implements of the contest
And of their death.

[Lines 5–39 are omitted. Penelope goes to her bedroom to fetch the key for the store room, where lies Odysseus's curved bow. It is a much treasured gift from a deceased friend of Odysseus. Odysseus has kept it at home as a memento of his friend.]

Penelope came to the storeroom
And stepped onto the oak threshold
Which a carpenter in the old days had planed,
Leveled, and then fitted with doorposts
And polished doors. Lovely in the half-light,
She quickly loosened the thong from the hook,
Drove home the key and shot back the bolts.
The doors bellowed like a bull in a meadow
And flew open before her. Stepping through,
She climbed onto a high platform that held chests
Filled with fragrant clothes. She reached up
And took the bow, case and all, from its peg,
Then sat down and laid the gleaming case on her knees
Her eyes welling with tears. Then she opened the case
And took out her husband's bow. When she had her fill
Of weeping, she went back to the hall
And the lordly suitors, bearing in her hands
The curved bow and the quiver loaded

With whining arrows. Two maidservants
Walked beside her, carrying a wicker chest
Filled with the bronze and iron gear her husband
Once used for this contest. When the beautiful woman
Reached the crowded hall, she stood
In the doorway flanked by her maidservants.
Then, covering her face with her shining veil,
Penelope spoke to her suitors:

"Hear me, proud suitors. You have used this house
For an eternity now—to eat and drink
In its master's absence, nor could you offer
Any excuse except your lust to marry me.
Well, your prize is here, and this is the contest.
I set before you the great bow of godlike Odysseus.
Whoever bends this bow and slips the string on its notch
And shoots an arrow through all twelve axes,
With him will I go, leaving behind this house
I was married in, this beautiful, prosperous house,
Which I will remember always, even in my dreams."

Penelope said this, and then ordered Eumaeus
To set out for the suitors the bow and grey iron.
All in tears, Eumaeus took them and laid them down,
And the cowherd wept, too, when he saw
His master's bow. Antinous scoffed at them both:

"You stupid yokels! You can't see farther than your own noses.
What a pair! Disturbing the lady with your bawling.
She's sad enough already because she's lost her husband.
Either sit here in silence or go outside to weep,
And leave the bow behind for us suitors. This contest
Will separate the men from the boys. It won't be easy
To string that polished bow. There is no man here
Such as Odysseus was. I know. I saw him myself
And remember him well, though I was still a child."

So Antinous said, hoping in his heart
That he would string the bow first and shoot an arrow

Through the iron. But the only arrow
He would touch first would be the one shot
Into his throat from the hands of Odysseus,
The man he himself was dishonoring
While inciting his comrades to do the same.

And then Telemachus, with a sigh of disgust:

"Look at me! Zeus must have robbed me of my wits.
My dear mother declares, for all her good sense,
That she will marry another and abandon this house,
And all I do is laugh and think it is funny.
Well, come on, you suitors, here's your prize,
A woman the likes of whom does not exist
In all Achaea, or in sacred Pylos,
Nowhere in Argos or in Mycenae,
Or on Ithaca itself or on the dark mainland.
You all know this. Why should I praise my mother?
Let's get going. Don't start making excuses
To put off stringing the bow. We'll see what happens.
And I might give that bow a try myself.
If I string it and shoot an arrow through the axeheads,
It won't bother me so much that my honored mother
Is leaving this house and going off with another,
Because I would at least be left here as someone
Capable of matching his father's prowess."

With that he took off his scarlet cloak, stood up,
And unstrapped his sword from his shoulders.
Then he went to work setting up the axeheads,
First digging a long trench true to the line
To hold them in a row, and then tamping the earth
Around each one. Everyone was amazed
That he made such a neat job of it
When he had never seen it done before.
Then he went and took his stance on the threshold
And began to try the bow. Three times
He made it quiver as he strained to string it,
And three times he eased off, although in his heart
He yearned to draw that bow and shoot an arrow

Through the iron axeheads. And on his fourth try
He would have succeeded in muscling the string
Onto its notch, but Odysseus reined him in,
Signaling him to stop with an upward nod.
So Telemachus said for all to hear:

"I guess I'm going to be a weakling forever!
Or else I'm still too young and don't have the strength
To defend myself against an enemy.
But come on, all of you who are stronger than me—
Give the bow a try and let's settle this contest."

And he set the bow aside, propping it against
The polished, jointed door, and leaning the arrow
Against the beautiful latch. Then Telemachus
Sat down on the chair from which he had risen.

[Lines 144–327 are omitted. The suitors take turns to string the bow. All try and fail, except Antinous and Eurymachus, the two strongest among them. Odysseus secretly reveals himself to the faithful cowherd and swineherd. When Eurymachus, too, fails to string the bow, Antinous proposes to feast in honour of the Archer God and continue with the contest the next day. Still in disguise, Odysseus asks to try the bow and is humiliated by Antinous.]

It was Penelope who answered Antinous:

"It is not good, or just, Antinous,
To cheat any of Telemachus' guests
Who come to this house. Do you think
That if this stranger proves strong enough
To string Odysseus' bow, he will then
Lead me to his home and make me his wife?
I can't imagine that he harbors this hope.
So do not ruin your feast on that account.
The very idea is preposterous."

Eurymachus responded to this:

"Daughter of Icarius, wise Penelope,
Of course it's preposterous that this man

Would marry you. That's not what we're worried about.
But we are embarrassed at what men—and women—will say:
'A bunch of weaklings were wooing the wife
Of a man they couldn't touch—they couldn't even string
His polished bow. Then along came a vagrant
Who strung it easily and shot through the iron.'
That's what they'll say, to our lasting shame."

And Penelope, her eyes narrowing:

"Eurymachus, men who gobble up
The house of a prince cannot expect
To have a good reputation anywhere.
So there isn't any point in bringing up honor.
This stranger is a very well-built man
And says he is the son of a noble father.
So give him the bow and let us see what happens.
And here is my promise to all of you.
If Apollo gives this man the glory
And he strings the bow, I will clothe him
In a fine cloak and tunic, and give him
A javelin to ward off dogs and men,
And a double-edged sword, and sandals
For his feet, and I will give him passage
To wherever his heart desires."

This time it was Telemachus who answered:

"As for the bow, Mother, no man alive
Has a stronger claim than I do to give it
To whomever I want, or to deny it—
No, none of the lords on rocky Ithaca
Nor on the islands over toward Elis,
None of them could force his will upon me,
Not even if I wanted to give this bow
Outright, case and arrows and all,
As a gift to the stranger.
Go to your rooms,
Mother, and take care of your work,

Spinning and weaving, and have the maids do theirs.
This bow is men's business, and my business
Especially, since I am the master of this house."

Penelope was stunned and turned to go,
Her son's masterful words pressed to her heart.
She went up the stairs to her room with her women
And wept for Odysseus, her beloved husband,
Until grey-eyed Athena cast sleep on her eyelids.

Downstairs, the noble swineherd was carrying
The curved bow across the hall. The suitors
Were in an uproar, and one of them called out:

"Where do you think you're going with that bow,
You miserable swineherd? You're out of line.
Go back to your pigsties, where your own dogs
Will wolf you down—a nice, lonely death—
If Apollo and the other gods smile upon us."

Afraid, the swineherd stopped in his tracks
And set the bow down. Men were yelling at him
All through the hall, and now Telemachus weighed in:

"Keep going with the bow. You'll regret it
If you try to obey everyone. I may be
Younger than you, but I'll chase you back
Into the country with a shower of stones.
I am stronger than you. I wish I were as strong
When it came to the suitors. I'd throw more than one
Out of here in a sorry state. They're all up to no good."

This got the suitors laughing hilariously
At Telemachus. The tension in the room eased,
And the swineherd carried the bow
Across to Odysseus and put it in his hands.
Then he called Eurycleia aside and said:

"Telemachus says you should lock the doors to the hall,

And if the women hear the sound of men groaning
Or being struck, tell them not to rush out
But to sit still and do their work in silence."

Eumaeus' words sank in, and Eurycleia
Locked the doors to the crowded hall.

Meanwhile, Philoetius left without a word
And barred the gates to the fenced courtyard.
Beside the portico there lay a ship's hawser
Made of papyrus. Philoetius used this
To secure the gates, and then he went back in,
Sat down on the chair from which he had risen,
And kept his eyes on Odysseus.

He was handling the bow, turning it over and over
And testing its flex to make sure that worms
Had not eaten the horn in its master's absence.
The suitors glanced at each other
And started to make sarcastic remarks:

"Ha! A real connoisseur, an expert in bows!"

"He must have one just like it in a case at home."

"Or plans to make one just like it, to judge by the way
The masterful tramp keeps turning it in his hands."

"May he have as much success in life
As he'll have in trying to string that bow."

Thus the suitors, while Odysseus, deep in thought,
Was looking over his bow. And then, effortlessly,

Like a musician stretching a string
Over a new peg on his lyre, and making
The twisted sheep-gut fast at either end,

Odysseus strung the great bow. Lifting it up,

He plucked the string, and it sang beautifully
Under his touch, with a note like a swallow's.
The suitors were aghast. The color drained
From their faces, and Zeus thundered loud,
Showing his portents and cheering the heart
Of the long-enduring, godlike Odysseus.
One arrow lay bare on the table. The rest,
Which the suitors were about to taste,
Were still in the quiver. Odysseus picked up
The arrow from the table and laid it upon
The bridge of the bow, and, still in his chair,
Drew the bowstring and the notched arrow back.
He took aim and let fly, and the bronze-tipped arrow
Passed clean through the holes of all twelve axeheads
From first to last. And he said to Telemachus:

"Well, Telemachus, the guest in your hall
Has not disgraced you. I did not miss my target,
Nor did I take all day in stringing the bow.
I still have my strength, and I'm not as the suitors
Make me out to be in their taunts and jeers.
But now it is time to cook these men's supper,
While it is still light outside, and after that,
We'll need some entertainment—music and song—
The finishing touches for a perfect banquet."
He spoke, and lowered his brows. Telemachus,
The true son of godlike Odysseus, slung on
His sharp sword, seized his spear, and gleaming in bronze
Took his place by his father's side.

[Book 22 is omitted. Odysseus reveals his true identity and shoots an arrow through Antinous's throat. Eurymachus tries to persuade Odysseus to spare the rest of the suitors, but Odysseus insists that they pay in full for having courted his wife. With the blessing of Athena, Odysseus's team of four, including Telemachus, the swineherd and the cowherd, kill all the suitors, sparing only the bard and the herald. Eurycleia names the twelve women servants who have had an amorous relation with the suitors. With Odysseus's consent, Telemachus hangs all twelve to death.]

ODYSSEY 23

The old woman laughed as she went upstairs
To tell her mistress that her husband was home.
She ran up the steps, lifting her knees high,
And, bending over Penelope, she said:

"Wake up, dear child, so you can see for yourself
What you have yearned for day in and day out.
Odysseus has come home, after all this time,
And has killed those men who tried to marry you
And who ravaged your house and bullied your son."

And Penelope, alert now and wary:

"Dear nurse, the gods have driven you crazy.
The gods can make even the wise mad,
Just as they often make the foolish wise.
Now they have wrecked your usually sound mind.
Why do you mock me and my sorrowful heart,
Waking me from sleep to tell me this nonsense—
And such a sweet sleep. It sealed my eyelids.
I haven't slept like that since the day Odysseus
Left for Ilion—that accursed city.
Now go back down to the hall.
If any of the others had told me this
And wakened me from sleep, I would have
Sent her back with something to be sorry about!
You can thank your old age for this at least."

And Eurycleia, the loyal nurse:

"I am not mocking you, child. Odysseus
Really is here. He's come home, just as I say.
He's the stranger they all insulted in the great hall.
Telemachus has known all along, but had
The self-control to hide his father's plans
Until he could pay the arrogant bastards back."

Penelope felt a sudden pang of joy. She leapt
From her bed and flung her arms around the old woman,
And with tears in her eyes she said to her:

"Dear nurse, if it is true, if he really has
Come back to his house, tell me how
He laid his hands on the shameless suitors,
One man alone against all of that mob."

Eurycleia answered her:

"I didn't see and didn't ask. I only heard the groaning
Of men being killed. We women sat
In the far corner of our quarters, trembling,
With the good solid doors bolted shut
Until your son came from the hall to call me,
Telemachus. His father had sent him to call me.
And there he was, Odysseus, standing
In a sea of dead bodies, all piled
On top of each other on the hard-packed floor.
It would have warmed your heart to see him,
Spattered with blood and filth like a lion.
And now the bodies are all gathered together
At the gates, and he is purifying the house
With sulfur, and has built a great fire,
And has sent me to call you. Come with me now
So that both your hearts can be happy again.
You have suffered so much, but now
Your long desire has been fulfilled.
He has come himself, alive, to his own hearth,
And has found you and his son in the hall.
As for the suitors, who did him wrong,
He's taken his revenge on every last man."

And Penelope, ever cautious:

"Dear nurse, don't gloat over them yet.
You know how welcome the sight of him
Would be to us all, and especially to me
And the son he and I bore. But this story

Can't be true, not the way you tell it.
One of the immortals must have killed the suitors,
Angry at their arrogance and evil deeds.
They respected no man, good or bad,
So their blind folly has killed them. But Odysseus
Is lost, lost to us here, and gone forever."

And Eurycleia, the faithful nurse:

"Child, how can you say this? Your husband
Is here at his own fireside, and yet you are sure
He will never come home! Always on guard!
But here's something else, clear proof:
The scar he got from the tusk of that boar.
I noticed it when I was washing his feet
And wanted to tell you, but he shrewdly clamped
His hand on my mouth and wouldn't let me speak.
Just come with me, and I will stake my life on it.
If I am lying you can torture me to death."

Still wary, Penelope replied:

"Dear nurse, it is hard for you to comprehend
The ways of the eternal gods, wise as you are.
Still, let us go to my son, so that I may see
The suitors dead and the man who killed them."

And Penelope descended the stairs, her heart
In turmoil. Should she hold back and question
Her husband? Or should she go up to him,
Embrace him, and kiss his hands and head?
She entered the hall, crossing the stone threshold,
And sat opposite Odysseus, in the firelight
Beside the farther wall. He sat by a column,
Looking down, waiting to see if his incomparable wife
Would say anything to him when she saw him.
She sat a long time in silence, wondering.
She would look at his face and see her husband,
But then fail to know him in his dirty rags.
Telemachus couldn't take it any more:

"Mother, how can you be so hard,
Holding back like that? Why don't you sit
Next to father and talk to him, ask him things?
No other woman would have the heart
To stand off from her husband who has come back
After twenty hard years to his country and home.
But your heart is always colder than stone."

And Penelope, cautious as ever:

"My child, I am lost in wonder
And unable to speak or ask a question
Or look him in the eyes. If he really is
Odysseus come home, the two of us
Will be sure of each other, very sure.
There are secrets between us no one else knows."

Odysseus, who had borne much, smiled,
And his words flew to his son on wings:

"Telemachus, let your mother test me
In our hall. She will soon see more clearly.
Now, because I am dirty and wearing rags,
She is not ready to acknowledge who I am.
But you and I have to devise a plan.
When someone kills just one man,
Even a man who has few to avenge him,
He goes into exile, leaving country and kin.
Well, we have killed a city of young men,
The flower of Ithaca. Think about that."

And Telemachus, in his clear-headed way:
"You should think about it, Father. They say
No man alive can match you for cunning.
We'll follow you for all we are worth,
And I don't think we'll fail for lack of courage."

And Odysseus, the master strategist:

"Well, this is what I think we should do.

First, bathe yourselves and put on clean tunics
And tell the women to choose their clothes well.
Then have the singer pick up his lyre
And lead everyone in a lively dance tune,
Loud and clear. Anyone who hears the sound,
A passerby or neighbor, will think it's a wedding,
And so word of the suitors' killing won't spread
Down through the town before we can reach
Our woodland farm. Once there we'll see
What kind of luck the Olympian gives us."

They did as he said. The men bathed
And put on tunics, and the women dressed up.
The godlike singer, sweeping his hollow lyre,
Put a song in their hearts and made their feet move,
And the great hall resounded under the tread
Of men and silken-waisted women dancing.
And people outside would hear it and say:

"Well, someone has finally married the queen,
Fickle woman. Couldn't bear to keep the house
For her true husband until he came back."

But they had no idea how things actually stood.

Odysseus, meanwhile, was being bathed
By the housekeeper, Eurynome. She
Rubbed him with olive oil and threw about him
A beautiful cloak and tunic. And Athena
Shed beauty upon him, and made him look
Taller and more muscled, and made his hair
Tumble down his head like hyacinth flowers.

Imagine a craftsman overlaying silver
With pure gold. He has learned his art
From Pallas Athena and Lord Hephaestus,
And creates works of breathtaking beauty.

So Athena herself made his head and shoulders

Shimmer with grace. He came from the bath
Like a god, and sat down on the chair again
Opposite his wife, and spoke to her and said:

"You're a mysterious woman.
The gods
Have given to you, more than to any
Other woman, an unyielding heart.
No other woman would be able to endure
Standing off from her husband, come back
After twenty hard years to his country and home.
Nurse, make up a bed for me so I can lie down
Alone, since her heart is a cold lump of iron."

And Penelope, cautious and wary:

"You're a mysterious man.
I am not being proud
Or scornful, nor am I bewildered—not at all.
I know very well what you looked like
When you left Ithaca on your long-oared ship.
Nurse, bring the bed out from the master bedroom,
The bedstead he made himself, and spread it for him
With fleeces and blankets and silky coverlets."

She was testing her husband.
Odysseus
Could bear no more, and he cried out to his wife:

"By God, woman, now you've cut deep.
Who moved my bed? It would be hard
For anyone, no matter how skilled, to move it.
A god could come down and move it easily,
But not a man alive, however young and strong,
Could ever pry it up. There's something telling
About how that bed's built, and no one else
Built it but me.
There was an olive tree
Growing on the site, long-leaved and full,

Its trunk thick as a post. I built my bedroom
Around that tree, and when I had finished
The masonry walls and done the roofing
And set in the jointed, close-fitting doors,
I lopped off all of the olive's branches,
Trimmed the trunk from the root on up,
And rounded it and trued it with an adze until
I had myself a bedpost. I bored it with an auger,
And starting from this I framed up the whole bed,
Inlaying it with gold and silver and ivory
And stretching across it oxhide thongs dyed purple.
So there's our secret. But I do not know, woman,
Whether my bed is still firmly in place, or if
Some other man has cut through the olive's trunk."

At this, Penelope finally let go.
Odysseus had shown he knew their old secret.
In tears, she ran straight to him, threw her arms
Around him, kissed his face, and said:

"Don't be angry with me, Odysseus. You,
Of all men, know how the world goes.
It is the gods who gave us sorrow, the gods
Who begrudged us a life together, enjoying
Our youth and arriving side by side
To the threshold of old age. Don't hold it against me
That when I first saw you I didn't welcome you
As I do now. My heart has been cold with fear
That an imposter would come and deceive me.
There are many who scheme for ill-gotten gains.
Not even Helen, daughter of Zeus,
Would have slept with a foreigner had she known
The Greeks would go to war to bring her back home.
It was a god who drove her to that dreadful act,
Or she never would have thought of doing what she did,
The horror that brought suffering to us as well.
But now, since you have confirmed the secret
Of our marriage bed, which no one has ever seen—
Only you and I and a single servant, Actor's daughter,

Whom my father gave me before I ever came here
And who kept the doors of our bridal chamber—
You have persuaded even my stubborn heart."

This brought tears from deep within him,
And as he wept he clung to his beloved wife.

Land is a welcome sight to men swimming
For their lives, after Poseidon has smashed their ship
In heavy seas. Only a few of them escape
And make it to shore. They come out
Of the grey water crusted with brine, glad
To be alive and set foot on dry land.

So welcome a sight was her husband to her.
She would not loosen her white arms from his neck,
And rose-fingered Dawn would have risen
On their weeping, had not Athena stepped in
And held back the long night at the end of its course
And stopped gold-stitched Dawn at Ocean's shores
From yoking the horses that bring light to men,
Lampus and Phaethon, the colts of Dawn.

Then Odysseus said to his wife:

"We have not yet come to the end of our trials.
There is still a long, hard task for me to complete,
As the spirit of Tiresias foretold to me
On the day I went down to the house of Hades
To ask him about my companions' return
And my own. But come to bed now,
And we'll close our eyes in the pleasure of sleep."

And Penelope calmly answered him:

"Your bed is ready for you whenever
You want it, now that the gods have brought you
Home to your family and native land.
But since you've brought it up, tell me

About this trial. I'll learn about it soon enough,
And it won't be any worse to hear it now."

And Odysseus, his mind teeming:

"You are a mystery to me. Why do you insist
I tell you now? Well, here's the whole story.
It's not a tale you will enjoy, and I have no joy
In telling it.
Tiresias told me that I must go
To city after city carrying a broad-bladed oar,
Until I come to men who know nothing of the sea,
Who eat their food unsalted, and have never seen
Red-prowed ships or the oars that wing them along.
And he told me that I would know I had found them
When I met another traveler who thought
The oar I was carrying was a winnowing fan.
Then I must fix my oar in the earth
And offer sacrifice to Lord Poseidon,
A ram, a bull, and a boar in its prime.
Then at last I am to come home and offer
Grand sacrifice to the immortal gods
Who hold high heaven, to each in turn.
And death shall come to me from the sea,
As gentle as this touch, and take me off
When I am worn out in sleek old age,
With my people prosperous around me.
All this Tiresias said would come true."

Then Penelope, watching him, answered:

"If the gods are going to grant you a happy old age,
There is hope your troubles will someday be over."

While they spoke to one another,
Eurynome and the nurse made the bed
By torchlight, spreading it with soft coverlets.
Then the old nurse went to her room to lie down,
And Eurynome, who kept the bedroom,

Led the couple to their bed, lighting the way.
When she had led them in, she withdrew,
And they went with joy to their bed
And to their rituals of old.

Telemachus and his men
Stopped dancing, stopped the women's dance,
And lay down to sleep in the shadowy halls.

After Odysseus and Penelope
Had made sweet love, they took turns
Telling stories to each other. She told him
All that she had to endure as the fair lady
In the palace, looking upon the loathsome throng
Of suitors, who used her as an excuse
To kill many cattle, whole flocks of sheep,
And to empty the cellar of much of its wine.
Odysseus told her of all the suffering
He had brought upon others, and of all the pain
He endured himself. She loved listening to him
And did not fall asleep until he had told the whole tale.

He began with how he overcame the Cicones
And then came to the land of the Lotus-Eaters,
And all that the Cyclops did, and how he
Paid him back for eating his comrades.
Then how he came to Aeolus,
Who welcomed him and sent him on his way,
But since it was not his destiny to return home then,
The stormwinds grabbed him and swept him off
Groaning deeply over the teeming saltwater.
Then how he came to the Laestrygonians,
Who destroyed his ships and all their crews,
Leaving him with only one black-tarred hull.
Then all of Circe's tricks and wiles,
And how he sailed to the dank house of Hades
To consult the spirit of Theban Tiresias
And saw his old comrades there
And his aged mother who nursed him as a child.

Then how he heard the Sirens' eternal song,
And came to the Clashing Rocks,
And dread Charybdis and Scylla,
Whom no man had ever escaped before.
Then how his crew killed the cattle of the Sun,
And how Zeus, the high lord of thunder,
Slivered his ship with lightning, and all his men
Went down, and he alone survived.
And he told her how he came to Ogygia,
The island of the nymph Calypso,
Who kept him there in her scalloped caves,
Yearning for him to be her husband,
And how she took care of him, and promised
To make him immortal and ageless all his days
But did not persuade the heart in his breast.
Then how he crawled out of the sea in Phaeacia,
And how the Phaeacians honored him like a god
And sent him on a ship to his own native land
With gifts of bronze and clothing and gold.

He told the story all the way through,
And then sleep, which slackens our bodies,
Fell upon him and released him from care.

The Grey-eyed One knew what to do next.
When she felt that Odysseus was satisfied
With sleep and with lying next to his wife,
She roused the slumbering, golden Dawn,
Who climbed from Ocean with light for the world.
Odysseus got up from his rose-shadowed bed
And turned to Penelope with these instructions:

"My wife, we've had our fill of trials now,
You here, weeping over all the troubles
My absence caused, and I, bound by Zeus
To suffer far from the home I yearned for.
Now that we have both come to the bed
We have long desired, you must take charge
Of all that is mine in the house, while I

See to replenishing the flocks and herds
The insolent suitors have depleted.
I'll get some back on raids, some as tribute,
Until the pens are full again. But now,
I want you to know I am going to our farm
To see my father, who has suffered terribly
On my account. You don't need me to tell you
That when the sun rises the news will spread
That I have killed the suitors in our hall. So,
Go upstairs with your women and sit quietly.
Don't look outside or speak to anyone."

Odysseus spoke and put on his beautiful armor.
He woke Telemachus, and the cowherd
And swineherd, and had them arm also.
They strapped on their bronze, opened the doors
And went out, Odysseus leading the way.
It was light by now, but Athena hid them
In darkness, and spirited them out of the city.

[Book 24 is omitted. Led by Hermes, the ghosts of the suitors reach the Underworld. Agamemnon rejoices at Odysseus's deeds and sings praises of Penelope. Odysseus reunites with his father Laertes, who then joins with Odysseus and Telemachus in dealing with some of the suitors' families, now desperate for revenge. When the two parties meet, Athena intervenes and makes them swear a binding oath of peace.]

GLOSSARY

(First appearance noted by book and line number.)

/əˈkiːənz/ ***Achaeans*** (A-kee′-unz): General term used by Homer to refer to Greeks. 2.139

/iːˈdʒɪsθəs/ ***Aegisthus*** (Ee-jis′-thus): Son of Thyestes and Pelopia. He seduces Clytemnestra, wife of Agamemnon, while Agamemnon is away fighting the Trojan War and helps her slay Agamemnon when he returns. Orestes avenges this action years later by murdering both Clytemnestra and Aegisthus. 1.35

/iːəʊləs/ ***Aeolus*** (Ee′-oh-lus): King of the island Aeolia and keeper of the winds. 10.2

/ˌægəˈmemnən/ ***Agamemnon*** (A-ga-mem′-non): Son of Atreus and Aerope; brother of Menelaus; husband of Clytemnestra. He commands the Greek forces in the Trojan War. He is killed by his wife and her lover when he returns home; his son, Orestes, avenges this murder. 1.36

/ælˈsɪnəʊəs/ ***Alcinous*** (Al-si′-no-us): Grandson of Poseidon; king of the Phaeacians; husband of Arete and father of Nausicaa. He graciously entertains Odysseus and gives him riches and safe transport to Ithaca. 6.12

/ælkˈmiːniː/ ***Alcmene*** (Alk-mee′-nee): Wife of Amphitryon; mother of Heracles (by Zeus). 2.131

/ænˈtɪnəʊəs/ ***Antinous*** (An-ti′-no-us): Son of Eupeithes; an Ithacan noble and the primary leader of Penelope's suitors. He is the first suitor slain by Odysseus. 1.404

/ˈæntɪfəs/ ***Antiphus*** (An′-ti-fus): Name given to two of Odysseus' companions, one of whom is the son of Aegyptius, the last of Odysseus' companions eaten by the Cyclops. 2.17

/ˌæfrəʊˈdaɪtiː/ ***Aphrodite*** (A-fro-deye′-tee): Goddess of love and beauty. Daughter of Zeus and Dione; wife of Hephaestus. During a sexual liaison, Aphrodite and Ares are caught in a trap set by Hephaestus and exposed to the laughter of the gods. 4.17

/əˈpɒləʊ/ ***Apollo*** (A-pol′-oh): Patron god of music and the arts. Son of Zeus and Leto; brother of Artemis. Also called Phoebus Apollo, he is associated with the lyre and archery. It is on the day of his festival that the suitors are murdered. 3.309

Argives (Ar′-geyvz): The Greeks who fight at Troy under the leadership of Agamemnon. 1.228 /ˈɑːgaɪvz/

Argos (Ar′-gos): City or district in the northeastern Peloponnese, Greek region of the Achaeans. 1.364 /ˈɑːgɒs/

Artemis (Ar′-te-mis): Goddess of the hunt and the moon. Daughter of Zeus and Leto; sister of Apollo. Like her brother, Artemis brings natural death to mortals, but she is the slaughterer of female mortals in particular. 4.127 /ˈɑːtɪmɪs/

Athena (A-thee′-na): Goddess of wisdom, crafts, and battle. Daughter of Zeus; usually said to have sprung from his head. She is also called Pallas Athena and the Grey-eyed One. She frequently appears to Odysseus and helps him return home. 1.49 /əˈθiːnə/

Atlas (At′-las): Titan who holds up the pillars of the sky; father of Calypso. 1.58 /ˈætləs/

Calypso (Ka-lip′-soh): Goddess, daughter of Atlas. Her name is a play on a Greek word meaning "to conceal." She detains Odysseus for seven years on her island, Ogygia, offering him immortality if he remains. 1.17 /kəˈlɪpsəʊ/

Charybdis (Ka-rib′-dis): Whirlpool situated opposite Scylla. 12.107 /kəˈrɪbdɪs/

Cicones (Si-koh′-neez): Allies of Troy, the first people Odysseus encounters (and raids) on his return home. Maron, the priest, gives Odysseus some excellent wine in return for sparing his and his family's lives. 9.42 /sɪˈkɔːniːz/

Circe (Sir′-see): Goddess and sorceress; daughter of Helios and Perse. When Odysseus lands on her island, Aeaea, she turns many of his men into swine, but Odysseus (with Hermes' help) resists her magic and convinces her to undo her spell. He and his men remain on her island for one year. 8.485 /ˈsɜːsɪ/

Crete: Island in the Aegean Sea south of the Peloponnese, ruled by Idomeneus. 3.210 /kriːt/

Cyclopes (Seye-klo′-peez): One-eyed, man-eating giants. Their occupation of Hyperia forces the Phaeacians to relocate. The term in the singular (Cyclops) also refers to Polyphemus. 1.76 /saɪˈkləʊpiːz/

Cyclops (Seye′-klops): See Cyclopes. /ˈsaɪklɒps/

/dəˈneɪənz/ ***Danaans*** (Da-nay′-unz): One of three general names Homer uses when referring to Greeks. The other two are Achaeans and Argives. 1.371

/diːˈmiːtə/ ***Demeter*** (Dee-mee′-tur): Goddess of crops and the harvest. Daughter of Cronus and Rhea; mother of Persephone. 5.125

/dəʊˈdəʊnə/ ***Dodona*** (Doh-doh′-na): City in northwestern Greece; home to a famous oracle of Zeus. 14.356

/ˈdɔːrɪənz/ ***Dorians*** (Doh′-ri-unz): Greek-speaking inhabitants of Crete. 19.191

/juːˈmiːəs/ ***Eumaeus*** (Yoo-mee′-us): Odysseus' loyal swineherd who generously hosts Odysseus, disguised as a beggar upon his return to Ithaca. Eumaeus later assists Odysseus in the slaughter of the suitors. 14.63

/juːˈpeɪθiːz/ ***Eupeithes*** (Yoo-pay′-theez): Father of Antinous. He rallies the relatives of the slain suitors against Odysseus and is killed by Laertes. 1.404

/juːˈrɒbətiːz/ ***Eurybates*** (Yoo-ri′-ba-teez): Round-shouldered, swarthy, and curly haired herald whom Odysseus values for his quick mind. 19.269

/ˌjʊrɪˈkleɪə/ ***Eurycleia*** (Yoo-ri-klay′-a): Daughter of Ops; nurse to Odysseus and later to Telemachus. She recognizes Odysseus' scar on his thigh but at his request does not reveal his identity. 1.452

/juːˈrɪməkəs/ ***Eurymachus*** (Yoo-ri′-ma-kus): One of Penelope's suitors. 1.421

/juːˈrɪnəmiː/ ***Eurynome*** (Yoo-ri′-no-mee): Penelope's housekeeper. 17.538

/juːˈrɪnəməs/ ***Eurynomus*** (Yoo-ri′-no-mus): Son of Antiphus; suitor to Penelope. 2.21

/ˈheɪdiːz/ ***Hades*** (Hay′-deez): God of the Underworld. Son of Cronus and Rhea. His name probably means "Unseen One." Also refers to the dwelling place of the dead, named for its ruler. 3.450

/ˈhelən/ ***Helen*** (He′-len): Daughter of Leda and Zeus or Tyndareus; wife of Menelaus. She is the most beautiful woman in the world and is given to Paris by Aphrodite. Menelaus' efforts to regain Helen are the basis of the Trojan War. 4.15

Helios (Hee′-li-os): The Sun God. 8.294 /ˈhiːlɪɒs/

Hephaestus (He-feyes′-tus): God of fire and patron of metalworkers and crafts. Son of Zeus and Hera. He marries Aphrodite, who is not always faithful. He forges Achilles' armor. 4.652 /hɪˈfaɪstəs/

Hermes (Hur′-meez): Divine messenger of the gods and guide to mortal travelers. Son of Zeus and Maia. 1.43 /ˈhɜːmiːz/

Icarius (I-ka′-ri-us): Father of Penelope; brother of Menelaus. 1.347 /ɪˈkaːrɪəs/

Ilion (Il′-i-on): Troy. 9.42 /ˈɪlɪən/

Ithaca (Ith′-a-ka): Rocky island home of Odysseus. 1.22 /ˈɪθəkə/

Laertes (Lay-er′-teez): Son of Arcesius; husband of Anticleia and father of Odysseus and Ctimene. 1.204 /leɪˈɜːtiːz/

Laestrygonians (Leye-stri-goh′-ni-unz): Giant cannibals who eat part of Odysseus' crew and destroy all the ships but Odysseus'. 10.95 /ˌlaɪstrɪˈgəʊnɪənz/

Medon (Mee′-don): Ithacan herald who remains faithful to his lord, Odysseus, and is spared when the suitors are killed. 4.722 /ˈmiːdən/

Melantho (Me-lan′-thoh): Daughter of Dolius; sister of Melanthius; handmaid of Penelope. She becomes the mistress of Eurymachus during Odysseus' absence and a deceitful antagonist. Telemachus hangs her for her betrayal. 18.350 /məˈlænθəʊ/

Menelaus (Me-ne-lay′-us): Son of Atreus and Aerope; brother of Agamemnon; ruler of Lacedaemon; husband of Helen. 1.303 /ˌmenɪˈleɪəs/

Mentes (Men′-teez): Taphian captain, son of Anchialus, in whose form Athena first appears to Telemachus. 1.112 /ˈmentiːz/

Mentor (Men′-tor): Close friend of Odysseus who is to look after the household during Odysseus' absence. Athena often appears in his form. 2.244 /ˈmentɔː/

Mycenae (Meye-see′-nee): Ancient city in Argos ruled by Agamemnon. 3.339 /maɪˈsiːniː/

/maɪˈsiːne/ ***Mycene*** (Meye-see′-neh): Legendary daughter of Inachus. The namesake of Mycenae. 2.131

/nɔːˈsɪkeɪə/ ***Nausicaa*** (Naw-si′-kay-a): Phaeacian princess; daughter of Alcinous and Arete. 6.17

/ˈnestɔː/ ***Nestor*** (Nes′-tor): Son of Neleus and Chloris; king of Pylos. He fights in the Trojan War, although already an old man, and is known for his valuable counsel. Father of Peisistratus, Thrasymedes, and Antilochus. 1.302

/əʊʃn/ ***Ocean***: The river encircling the earth. Son of Uranus and Earth; husband of Tethys. 4.597

/əʊˈdɪsjuːs/ ***Odysseus*** (O-dis′-yoos): Son of Laertes and Anticlea; husband of Penelope; father of Telemachus. *Odysseus* may mean either "giver of woe" or "woeful one." 1.15

/əʊˈdʒɪdʒə/ ***Ogygia*** (Oh-gi′-ja): Mythical island where the nymph Calypso resides. 1.92

/əʊˈlɪmpəs/ ***Olympus*** (O-lim′-pus): Mount Olympus, the tallest mountain in Greece, believed to be the abode of the gods. 1.109

/ɒps/ ***Ops*** (Ops): Father of Eurycleia, nurse to Odysseus and Telemachus. 1.452

/ɒˈrestiːz/ ***Orestes*** (O-res′-teez): Son of Agamemnon and Clytemnestra. He avenges his father's murder by killing his mother and her lover, Aegisthus. 1.36

/ɒˈraɪən/ ***Orion*** (O-reye′-on): Mythical hunter famed for his size and handsome looks. The goddess Dawn falls in love with him and bears him away to her island, Ortygia. The other gods become envious of the love affair and urge Artemis to slay the hunter. 5.121

/ˈpælæs/ ***Pallas*** (Pal′-as): Epithet of the goddess Athena that may mean "maiden" or "weapon-brandishing." 1.134

/pænˈdaːrjuːs/ ***Pandareus*** (Pan-dar′-yoos): A king of Miletas in Crete; father of Aedon. He steals a golden dog from the temple of Zeus in Crete, and consequently both he and his wife are killed. 19.566

/pɪˈneləpiː/ ***Penelope*** (Pe-ne′-lo-pee): Daughter of Icarius and Periboea; wife of Odysseus; mother of Telemachus. 1.240

GLOSSARY

Phaeacia (Fee-ay′-sha): See Phaeacians. /fiːˈeɪʃə/

Phaeacians (Fee-ay′-shunz): The people who inhabit Phaeacia (sometimes called Scheria). As descendants of Poseidon they are loved by the gods and have remarkable seafaring abilities. According to legend, they have ships that move without the aid of rudder or sail. 5.37 /fiːˈeɪʃnz/

Phemius (Fee′-mi-us): Son of Terpius; a bard in Ithaca. Although he is forced to entertain the suitors, he remains faithful to the house of Laertes. Odysseus spares him because of his fidelity. 1.165 /fiːˈmɪəs/

Philoetius (Fi-lee′-tee-us): Cowherd who remains faithful to Odysseus. 20.197 /fɪˈliːtiːəs/

Phorcys (For′-kis): Sea-god; father of Thoösa; grandfather of Polyphemus. 1.78 /ˈfɔːkɪs/

Pleiades (Plee′-a-deez): A constellation of seven stars used by ancient seamen for nocturnal navigation. The Pleiades were originally the seven daughters of Atlas and Pleione. 5.272 /ˈpliːədiːz/

Polybus (Pol′-i-bus): Father of Eurymachus, 1.421; Theban man visited by Menelaus and Helen, 4.131; Phaeacian craftsman, 8.412; one of Penelope's suitors killed by Eumaeus. 22.259 /ˈpɔlɪbəs/

Polyphemus (Po-li-fee′-mus): One of the Cyclopes, son of Poseidon and Thoösa. This one-eyed giant consumes some of Odysseus' men after he traps them in his cave. To escape from the cave, Odysseus and his men drive a heated pole into Polyphemus' only eye. As punishment for his son's blinding, Poseidon torments Odysseus until he reaches Ithaca. 1.76 /ˌpɒlɪˈfiːməs/

Poseidon (Po-seye′-don): God of the sea. Son of Cronus and Rhea; brother of Zeus, Hades, and Hera; father of the Cyclops Polyphemus. 1.25 /pəˈsaɪdən/

Priam (Preye′-am): King of Troy; son of Laomedon and Strymo; husband of Hecuba; father of Hector and Paris. He is killed by Neoptolemus as Troy falls to the Greeks. 3.118 /ˈpraɪəm/

Pylos (Peye-los): City on the southwest coast of the Peloponnese ruled by Nestor. 1.100 /ˈpaɪlɒs/

/skeˈrɪə/ ***Scheria*** (Ske-ri′-a): The island inhabited by the Phaeacians. 6.8

/ˈsɪlə/ ***Scylla*** (Sil′-a): The cave-dwelling monster possessing female attributes from the waist up but six dog heads and a dozen canine feet from the waist down. *Scylla* is Greek for "she-pup." She inhabits the cliff across the strait from Charybdis. 12.88

/ˈsaɪərənz/ ***Sirens*** (Seye′-rens): Singing creatures with female heads and breasts, and large birdlike bodies. They lure sailors to their island with an irresistible song. 12.41

/ˈspɑːtə/ ***Sparta*** (Spar′-ta): City in the southwest Peleponnese that was ruled by Menelaus. 1.100

/stɪks/ ***Styx*** (Stix): One of the rivers that flows near Hades. When gods swear by this river their oaths are irretractable. 5.184

/ˈtæftənz/ ***Taphians*** (Ta′-fi-unz): The inhabitants of Taphos, a seafaring people ruled by Mentes. Taphos is a city on the west coast of Greece. 1.112

/tɪˈleməkəs/ ***Telemachus*** (Te-lem′-a-kus): Son of Odysseus and Penelope. His name means "battle from afar." 1.121

/θiːmɪs/ ***Themis*** (The′-mis): Titan goddess of law and order. Daughter of Uranus and Gaia. 2.73

/ðoˈəʊsə/ ***Thoösa*** (Tho-oh′-sa): A nymph; mother of Polyphemus by Poseidon. 1.77

/θrɪˈneɪʃə/ ***Thrinacia*** (Thri-nay′-sha): Island where Helios' cattle pastured. 11.105

/taɪˈriːstæs/ ***Tiresias*** (Teye-ree′-si-as): The blind seer from Thebes whose shade counsels Odysseus in the Underworld. 10.514

/tɪˈðəʊnəs/ ***Tithonus*** (Ti-thoh′-nus): Son of Laomedon and husband of Dawn. 5.2

/ˈtrəʊdʒənz/ ***Trojans*** (Troh′-junz): The inhabitants of Troy. 3.94

/trɔɪ/ ***Troy*** (Troy): City in northwestern Asia Minor; ruled by Priam; conquered by the Greeks in the Trojan War. Site at which the *Iliad* takes place. 1.3

Zeus (Zyoos): The supreme god of Olympus, known as the father of gods and men. Son of Cronus and Rhea; husband and brother of Hera; father of Athena, Aphrodite, Ares, Apollo, Artemis, Hephaestus, and others. 1.33 /zjuːs/